

María Carmen López García

Socialism and Positive Science (Darwin–Spencer–Marx)

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POSITIVE SCIENCE
(DARWIN-SPENCER-MARX)**

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by María Carmen López García



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PREFACE

While I am at work on the second edition of an old essay of mine on *Socialism and Criminality* (Turin, 1883), in which, following the progressive evolution of my scientific thought, I mean to complete the *sociological* ideas of that time with the *socialist* ideas of today, I wish to publish this work, which was in part the lecture delivered at Milan on the first of May of the present year.

A convinced Darwinist and Spencerian, I propose to show how Marxist socialism—the only socialism that has a method and a scientifically positive value, and for that very reason the only one that now inspires and guides, as a single body, the democratic socialists of the whole civilized world—is nothing but the practical and fruitful complement, in social life, of that modern scientific revolution which the Italian renewal of the experimental method prepared in past centuries through every branch of human knowledge, and which the works of Darwin and Spencer have carried out and disciplined in our own day.

It is true that Darwin, and Spencer above all, stopped halfway toward the ultimate conclusions of the religious, political and social order that follow from their indestructible premises of fact.

But that personal episode, which cannot halt the inevitable progress of regenerated science and of its practical consequences—in formidable agreement with the most painful necessities of contemporary life—, does nothing, for the rest, but make still plainer the historical justice due to the scientific and political work of Karl Marx, in whom the great renovating trinity of modern scientific thought is completed.

* * *

Feeling and idea are the two inseparable forces that drive the life of the individual and of the collectivity.

Socialism, which until a few years ago lay at the mercy of the lively but undisciplined, and therefore inconclusive, fluctuations of humanitarian feeling, has found in the work of genius of Marx, and of those who have developed and completed it, its scientific and political compass. This is the reason for its daily conquests in every manifestation of the life of feeling and of the intellect.

Civilization, at the same time that it represents the complicated, fruitful and beautiful unfolding of human energies, is also an infectious *virus* of terrible power. Beside the splendors of artistic, scientific and industrial labor it heaps up the gangrened products of idleness, of destitution, of madness, of crime, of physical suicide, and of that moral suicide which is called servility.

Pessimism—a painful symptom of life without ideals, and in great measure the effect of exhaustion or of degeneration of the nervous system—commends final annihilation as the cessation of pain.

We, on the contrary, have faith in the eternal “medicinal virtue of nature”; and socialism is precisely that inward breath of a new and better life which will free humanity—though by a feverish process—from the virulent products of the present phase of civilization, in order to preserve and make young again, in a later phase, the sound and fruitful energies, for the good of all mankind.

Rome, June 1894.

ENRICO FERRI.

PART ONE



DARWINISM AND SOCIALISM

CHAPTER I

VIRCHOW AND HAECKEL AT THE MUNICH CONGRESS

On the 18th of September, 1877, at the congress of naturalists in Munich, Ernst Haeckel, the famous embryologist of Jena, delivered an eloquent address in defense and in advocacy of Darwinism, which was then passing through its sharpest and stormiest period of controversy and struggle.

A few days later Virchow, the great pathologist—who, although he now sits with the “progressive” party in parliament, is a good deal of a *misoneist* in politics as well as in science—attacked the Darwinian theory of organic evolution with great energy, and against it, with the keenest foresight, raised the cry of alarm and the political anathema, saying that “Darwinism leads straight to socialism.”

The Darwinists, with Oscar Schmidt and Haeckel at their head, protested at once; and in order that this grave political misgiving should not be added to all the religious, philosophical and biological opposition then raised against Darwinism, they maintained that the Darwinian theory was, on the contrary, in open and absolute contradiction with socialism.

“If the socialists were shrewd rogues (wrote Professor Oscar Schmidt in the *Ausland* of the 27th of November, 1877), they would do everything in their power to smother the theory of descent in silence, for that doctrine proclaims in the plainest terms that socialist ideas are unworkable.”

“Indeed,” added Haeckel, “there is no scientific doctrine that declares more openly than the Darwinian theory that the equality of individuals toward which socialism tends is an impossibility, and that this chimerical equality stands in absolute contradiction to the necessary inequality of fact which exists everywhere among individuals.

"Socialism asks for all citizens equal rights, equal duties, equal goods and equal enjoyments; the theory of heredity establishes, on the contrary, that the realization of these aspirations is purely and simply impossible; that in human societies, as in animal societies, neither the rights, nor the duties, nor the property, nor the enjoyments of all the associated individuals are, or ever can be, equal.

"The great law of differentiation teaches that, in the general theory of evolution as well as in its biological branch, the theory of heredity, the variety of phenomena arises out of an original unity, the difference of functions out of a primitive identity, the complexity of the organism out of a primordial simplicity. From the moment of entry into life the conditions of existence are unequal for all individuals. Add inherited qualities and innate dispositions more or less unlike one another, and how could our tasks in life, and their consequent results, be everywhere equal?

"The more developed social life becomes, the more importance the great principle of the division of labor acquires, and the more the lasting existence of the state requires that its members share out among themselves the many and various duties of life; and since the work that individuals have to perform, along with the outlay of strength, of talent, of means and the rest that it demands, differ in the highest degree, it is natural also that the reward of that work should be proportionately unequal.

"These are facts so simple and so evident that every intelligent and cultivated statesman ought, as it seems to me, to recommend the theory of heredity and the general doctrine of evolution as the best antidote to the absurd egalitarian utopias of the socialists.

"And it is Darwinism, or the theory of selection, that Virchow has taken as the target of his denunciation, rather than transformism, or the theory of heredity, which is forever confounded with it! Darwinism is anything but socialist.

"If political tendencies are to be attributed to this English doctrine—and it is fair enough to do so—those tendencies could only be aristocratic, never democratic, and least of all socialist.

"The theory of selection teaches that in the life of humanity, as in that of plants and animals, always and everywhere only a feeble minority manages to live and develop; the immense majority, on the

contrary, suffers and succumbs more or less prematurely. Past all counting are the germs of every vegetable and animal species, and the young individuals that never come to flower; but the number of those which have the good fortune to develop to their full maturity, and to reach the natural close of their existence, is by comparison insignificant.

"The cruel and pitiless 'struggle for life,' savage throughout animate nature, and bound by its own nature to be so, that eternal and inexorable competition among all that lives, is an undeniable fact. Only the scant number of the elect, of the strongest and the fittest, is in a condition to sustain that competition victoriously; the great majority of the luckless competitors must necessarily perish.

"That this tragic fatality should be deplored is well enough; but it can neither be denied nor altered. All are called; few are chosen!

"The selection, the *choosing* of these chosen ones, is necessarily bound up with the defeat or the destruction of the great number of beings that are outlived. That is why another English man of science has called the fundamental principle of Darwinism 'the survival of the fittest, the victory of the best.'

"In any case, then, the principle of selection is in no way democratic; it is rather fundamentally aristocratic. If Darwinism carried to its ultimate consequences has—according to Virchow—'an extremely dangerous side' for the statesman, that side consists, no doubt, in its favoring aristocratic aspirations."

* * *

I have copied out Haeckel's argument *in extenso*, because it is exactly the argument—in a different tone, and in expressions more or less precise and eloquent—repeated by those adversaries of socialism who are fond of striking scientific attitudes and who make use, for convenience in controversy, of the ready-made phrases that pass current, even in science itself, more widely than one would think.

It is easy to show, however, that in this debate Virchow's eye was the surer and the clearer, since the history of the last twenty years has proved him entirely right.

What has happened, in fact, is that Darwinism and socialism have advanced together with a marvelous power of expansion, the one win-

ning for its fundamental doctrine the unanimous assent of the naturalists, the other continuing to spread—in its general aspirations as much as in its political discipline—through every pore of the social conscience, now like a torrential flood over whole territories, driven by the daily increase of material and moral distress, now by a slow, capillary, irrevocable infiltration into the minds least burdened with care and least servile to the self-interest of orthodox meanness.

Now, just as political and scientific theories are natural phenomena like any other, and not the capricious and short-lived ornament of the private will of whoever starts them and spreads them, so it is also evident that if these two currents of modern thought have been able, together, to overcome the first and strongest opposition of scientific and political misoneism, and if together they swell day by day the ranks of their conscious partisans, that fact alone means—I would almost say by a law of intellectual *symbiosis*—that they are neither irreconcilable nor contradictory to each other.

But there is more. The three principal arguments to which Haeckel's anti-socialist reasoning reduces itself in substance will stand up neither to the most elementary criticism of scientific notions nor to the most superficial observation of ordinary life.

1. Socialism tends toward a chimerical equality of everyone and of everything; Darwinism, on the contrary, not only establishes but also explains the organic reasons for the natural inequality of men in their aptitudes, and therefore in their needs.

2. In the life of humanity, as in that of plants and animals, the immense majority of those born are destined to succumb, because only a small minority comes out victorious in the "struggle for life." Socialism, on the contrary, claims that all ought to win in that struggle and that none ought to succumb in it.

3. The struggle for life secures "the survival of the best and the fittest," and follows an aristocratic procedure of individualist selection rather than the democratic collectivist leveling of socialism.

CHAPTER II

EQUALITY AMONG MEN

The first of these objections raised against socialism in the name of Darwinism has no foundation whatever.

If it were true that socialism aspires to the *equality of all men*, nothing would be more exact: Darwinism would condemn it beyond appeal.

But although to this day many people, in good faith, as listeners who repeat ready-made phrases, or in bad faith, out of controversial adroitness, maintain that socialism is a synonym for equality and leveling, the truth is on the contrary that scientific socialism (that is, the socialism inspired by Marx's theory, which is the only one today that deserves either to be defended or attacked) in no way denies the inequality of men, nor that of other living beings, an inequality both innate and acquired, physical and moral.

It would be like saying that socialism demands, for instance, that by decree of the king or of the people it be laid down that: "From this day forward, all men shall be one meter seventy centimeters tall! . . ."

But socialism is something more serious and less easy to fight.

What socialism says is: *Men are unequal, but they are men.*

And so, even though every human individual is born and develops in a way more or less different from all the rest (for just as in a forest there are no two identical leaves, so in the whole world there are no two perfectly equal men), every man, by the simple fact of being *a man*, ought to be assured an existence fit for a man and not for a helot or a beast of burden.

We too know that not all men can carry out the same work, now that social inequalities aggravate natural ones; nor will they be able to under the socialist regime, when the social organization will tend, on the contrary, to soften congenital inequalities.

There will always be some whose brain and muscles are better fitted for scientific or artistic labor and others fitted for manual work, or for mechanical precision, or for agricultural effort, and so on.

What there ought not to be, and what there will not be, is men who do no work at all, and others who work a great deal or are very badly rewarded.

Nor is that all: the height of injustice and absurdity is that at present it is the man who does not work who receives the greatest rewards, secured to him by the individual monopoly of wealth, which can be piled up by hereditary transmission; wealth which in the smallest number of cases is owing to sacrifices of saving and to the inhuman privations of its present holder or of some industrious ancestor, and which is almost always the secular fruit of spoliation by military conquest, by scarcely creditable trade, or by the favor of sovereigns; wealth in every case independent of any effort, of any socially useful work on the part of the heir, who is often a swift squanderer in the various forms of an idleness more or less varnished over, and of a life as empty as it is brilliant to look at.

And where the wealth is not inherited, it is wealth obtained by fraud. Setting aside the economic mechanism of which I shall speak later, revealed by Karl Marx, by which, even apart from fraud, the capitalist or proprietor can regularly accumulate a rent or a profit without working; setting that aside, I say, it is a fact that the fortunes most rapidly amassed or swollen before our eyes neither are nor can be the fruit of honest labor.

The really honest workman, and therefore the tireless and thrifty one, who succeeds in rising from the condition of a wage earner to that of a factory head or an employer, may in a long lifetime of privation accumulate a few thousand lire at most. Those, on the other hand, who without any industrial discovery of their own gather millions in a few years can be nothing but unscrupulous men of business, apart from some exceptional case of an honest stroke of fortune. And these are the men who—parasites of the banks and of public business—live like lords, covered with carnival decorations and official honors . . . the reward of their good deeds.

And conversely, those who do work, who are the immense majority, have no other reward than food and lodging barely sufficient to keep

them from dying of sheer hunger, and whose cheap eating houses, whose garrets, whose foul back streets in the great cities, or whose hovels in the country, would not be thought fit for stables or cattle sheds! . . .

And to this must be added the desperate convulsions of enforced unemployment, which is one of the three most painful and most rapidly growing symptoms of that *equality in poverty* now spreading through the economic world in Italy and, more or less, everywhere.

I mean the immense army of the *unemployed* among agricultural and industrial workers, of the *abandoned* among the lower middle class, of the *expropriated* by taxes, debts or usury among the small proprietors.

It is not true, then, that socialism asks for all citizens a material and positive equality of work and of pleasures.

Equality can only take the form of the obligation of every man to work in order to live, the conditions of a *human* existence being assured to every individual in exchange for the labor given to society.

Equality among men according to socialism—as Malon used to say—must therefore be understood in a double relative sense.

1. That all men, as men, should have the conditions of a human existence assured to them.
2. That, consequently, men should be equal at the *starting point* of the struggle for existence, so that each may develop his personality freely, under equal social conditions.

* * *

As things are, the child who is born healthy and sturdy but poor is bound to go under in the competition with the child born weak but rich.

This is precisely the radical and immense transformation that socialism not only demands, but points out and foresees as an evolution already begun in present humanity—and necessary, inevitable, in the humanity of the near future.

A transformation consisting in the conversion of private or individual property in the means of production, that is, in the physical basis of human life (land, mines, houses, factories, machines, tools of labor,

means of transport), into collective or social property, by the methods and procedures I shall have to take up further on.

Meanwhile it is proved that the first objection of the anti-socialist argument has no substance at all, simply because it starts from a premise that does not exist: that is, it assumes that modern socialism asserts and wants a chimerical physical and moral equality of all men, of which scientific and positive socialism never so much as dreams.

On the contrary, socialism asserts that this inequality among men (which under a better social organization will have to be immensely softened, by doing away with all the organic and physical defects that poverty goes on accumulating from generation to generation) cannot as yet disappear, and this precisely for the reasons that Darwinism has discovered in the mysterious mechanism of life and in the endless succession of individuals and of species.

Under any social organization whatever, however one may imagine it, there will always be tall men and short men, weak and strong, sanguine and nervous, more or less intelligent, men in whom the muscles predominate and men in whom the brain does; it is well that this should be so, and besides it is inevitable.

And it is well that it should be so, because out of the variety and inequality of individual aptitudes there springs up of itself that division of labor which Darwinism points out as a law both of individual physiology and of social economy.

All men must live by working: but each must do the work that best answers to his aptitudes, so as to avoid a harmful waste of force and also so that work may not be repugnant, and may even become pleasant and necessary as a condition of physical and moral health.

Men who have given society the work that best answers to their innate and acquired aptitudes are equally deserving, because they contribute equally to that solidarity of labor which determines the life of the social body and, in solidarity with it, the life of each individual.

The peasant who tills the soil does work that is humbler in appearance but no less necessary, useful and deserving than that of the workman who builds a locomotive, or of the engineer who improves it, or of the man of science who wrestles with the unknown in a study or a laboratory.

The essential thing is that all should work in society, just as in the individual organism all the cells perform their various functions, more

or less humble in appearance—as between nerve cells and muscle and bone cells—but biological functions and labors equally necessary and useful to the life of the whole organism.

And as in the biological organism no living cell is without work, but draws its nourishment as the material reward of the work it does, so in the social organism no individual ought to live without work, of whatever kind that work may be.

And here, now, is how many of the artificial difficulties that the adversaries of socialism raise against it melt away.

“Who will black the boots under the socialist regime?” asks Richter in that bloodless book of his, which goes so far as the grotesque supposition that, in the name of social equality, “the Grand Chancellor” of socialist society will be obliged, before turning to public affairs, to polish his own shoes and mend his own clothes! Truly, if the adversaries of socialism had no better arguments than this, discussion would be perfectly useless.

“But everyone will want to do the least tiring and the most agreeable work,” it is said, with a greater show of seriousness.

To which we again reply that this is much the same as appealing here and now to a decree declaring:

From this day forward all men shall be born painters or surgeons.

But it is precisely the anthropological varieties of temperament and character that will distribute the various intellectual and manual tasks, with no need of monastic regimentation (another groundless objection against socialism).

Tell a peasant of average build to go and study anatomy or the penal code; tell a man whose brain is more developed than his muscles to go and plow instead of observing through a microscope: each will prefer the work for which he is better fitted.

Nor will the disorder of the professions be as great as many fantastically make out, once society is ordered on the collectivist plan. With the abolition of industries of mere *personal* luxury—which so often amount to an indecent sarcasm upon the poverty of the many—the sum and the variety of work will adapt itself gradually, that is to say naturally, to the phase of socialist civilization, as it now corresponds to the phase of bourgeois civilization.

Under the socialist regime each man will have greater freedom to strengthen and apply his own aptitudes, and it will not happen as it

does now, that for want of money many peasants and townsmen and small tradesmen endowed with natural intelligence remain stunted and are obliged to be farm laborers, workmen or clerks, when they might give society a different and more fruitful kind of work, better suited to their particular qualities.

The essential point is simply that the farm laborer and the professional man alike, since both give their work to society, should have assured to them by society the conditions of an existence worthy of human beings. In this way an end will also be put to the unworthy spectacle of, for instance, a dancer earning in a single night by her pirouettes what a man of science or a professional man receives for a whole year's work, when he is not the very image of poverty in a frock coat.

The fine arts will live under the socialist regime, because socialism wants life to be pleasant for all—and not, as now, for a few privileged people—and will therefore give a great and wonderful impulse to all the arts, abolishing private luxury but encouraging splendor in public buildings and public gatherings.

Meanwhile, greater respect will be paid to the proportion of the reward assured to each according to the work done. Proportions which will also be reduced by shortening the hours of work in proportion to its harshness or its danger; so that if a peasant might work seven or eight hours a day in the open air, a miner should work three or four. Indeed, when all work and many unproductive occupations have been done away with, the total sum of daily labor, shared out among all men, will be far less heavy and more bearable (with better food and lodging and with recreation assured) than it now is for those who work and who are so ill rewarded; and this is not the only thing to be considered, for the advances of science applied to industry will make human labor less and less fatiguing.

That is why work itself will be sought out spontaneously by all, in spite of there being no wage or payment that can be hoarded as private wealth; and precisely because the healthy, normal, well-fed man, just as he flies from excessive and ill-rewarded work, flies also from idleness, feeling a real and proper physiological and mental need of daily occupation suited to his aptitudes.

We see this every day, in fact, in the idle class, which seeks in the various more or less tiring forms of *sport* a substitute for productive

work, precisely as a physiological necessity, to avoid the injuries of absolute idleness and of boredom.

The difficult problem will then be how to *proportion* the reward to the work done by each. It is well known that collectivism adopts the formula:

"To each according to the work he has done,"

while communism adopts the other:

"To each according to his needs."

No one can say *à priori* how this problem will be solved *in its practical details*; but this impossibility of prophesying the future in detail is unfairly urged against socialism in order to brand it an unrealizable utopia. No one could have prophesied *à priori*, at the dawn of any civilization whatever, its successive developments, as I shall say later on when I speak of the methods of social renewal.

What we can say with complete confidence, on the other hand, from the soundest inferences of psychology and sociology, is this:

It is undeniable, as Karl Marx also recognized, that this second formula—which for some is what distinguishes anarchism (theoretical and platonic) from socialism—represents a further and more complicated ideal. But it is equally undeniable that, in any case, the formula of collectivism represents a phase of social evolution and of individual discipline that must necessarily come before that of communism.

We are not to suppose that with socialism humanity will completely realize every possible ideal, and that afterward it will have nothing left to desire or to conquer! . . .

Posterity would be condemned to idleness and vagrancy if we claimed to exhaust every possible human ideal.

The individual or the society that no longer has an ideal to fight for is dead or dying. The formula of communism may therefore be a further ideal to be won, once collectivism has come into full operation by the historical processes I shall deal with further on.

But for the present, to come back to Darwin, the alleged contradiction between socialism and Darwinism is thus disposed of, so far as it concerns that equality of all men of which socialism never dreams and which, on Darwinian grounds, it does not want either.

This also answers the endlessly repeated objection that socialism means to stifle and suppress the human personality under the uni-

form leaden pall of the collectivity, reducing the individual to the monastic function of one bee among many in the social hive.

The very opposite is the case.

For it is plain that the stunting and the loss of so many personalities which might have come forward, greatly to their own advantage and to that of others, happen now, under the present bourgeois organization, in which every man—save for the rare exceptions of the most outstanding individualities—counts for what he *has* and not for what he *is*.

A man born poor—through no fault of his own, of course—may have come from nature's hands an artistic or scientific genius; but if he has no patrimony of his own to give him the means of winning his first battles for life and of completing his education, or if the shepherd Giotto is not lucky enough to fall in with the wealthy Cimabue . . . then that intelligence must go out and be extinguished in the immense prison house of the wage earners, and society itself loses treasures of intellectual force.

The man born rich, on the other hand, through no doing of his own, may be a microcephalic or a mere fool; but he is certain of reaching the front of the social stage, and all the servile will be lavish toward him in praise and caresses, and simply because he *has* money he will believe himself to be other than he *is*.

With collective property, on the contrary, that is to say under the socialist regime—each individual having his conditions of life assured—daily work will serve only to bring to light the special aptitudes, more or less remarkable, of each man, and the best and most fruitful years of life will not be consumed, as they are now, in the desperate, convulsive and degrading conquest of daily bread.

Under socialism all will have, along with the security of a human existence, the real freedom to develop and display their own physical and moral personality, just as they received it at birth, in that infinite anthropological variety and inequality which socialism does not deny, but which it wishes to see better directed toward the free and fruitful unfolding of human life.

CHAPTER III

THE VANQUISHED IN THE STRUGGLE FOR LIFE

The second contradiction alleged between socialism and Darwinism is that, while Darwinism shows how the immense majority of those born—among plants, animals and men—are destined to succumb, since only a small minority comes out victorious in the “struggle for life,” socialism claims on the contrary that all shall triumph in that struggle and that none shall succumb in it.

Several answers may be given.

The first is that in the biological field of the struggle for life itself, the disproportion between the individuals born and the individuals that survive grows steadily less as we pass from plants to animals and from animals to man.

Moreover, this law of decreasing disproportion between the “called” and the “chosen” holds good also for the various species of one and the same natural order.

In the vegetable order, in fact, each individual produces every year an inordinate number of seeds, of which only an infinitesimal part survives. In the animal order, the number born of each individual falls and the number of survivors rises. In the human order, meanwhile, the number of births that each individual can produce is very small, but the greater part of them survive.

Nor is that all; in the vegetable order as in the animal and the human, the lower and simpler species, the less elevated races and classes, are those whose individuals have the greater generative abundance and the more rapid generation, in exchange for a shorter life in the individual.

A fern produces millions of spores and lives a short time, while a palm gives a few dozen seeds a year and lives for centuries.

A fish produces many thousands of eggs, while the elephant and the chimpanzee have few young and live many years.

Among men, the savage races are more prolific and short-lived, while the civilized races have a low birth rate and a greater length of life.

So that, even keeping strictly to biological ground, it is plain that the proportion of the victors in the "struggle for life" rises steadily against the total of those born, as we pass from plants to animals, from animals to men, and as we go from the lower species or variety to the higher races or varieties.

That same iron law of the struggle for life thus goes on reducing the slaughter of the vanquished, in proportion as the forms of that same life rise, growing more complex and more perfect.

It would therefore be a mistake to set socialism, without further argument, against the Darwinian law of natural selection as it shows itself in the primitive forms of life, taking no account of its steady abatement in the passage from plants to animals, from animals to man, and within humanity itself from the primitive races to the more advanced ones.

Since socialism represents a further phase of progress in the life of humanity, no such coarse and inexact reading of the Darwinian law can be brought against it.

* * *

It is true that the adversaries of socialism have abused the Darwinian law, or rather that "brutal" interpretation of it, in the attempt to justify modern individualist competition, which too often turns into a disguised form of cannibalism, and makes a feature of the present social state of that condition of *homo homini lupus* which Hobbes, on the contrary, placed in the supposed *natural* state of man, before the contract of social life.

But the abuse of a scientific principle is no proof of its falsity; rather it serves as a spur to define its character and its terms more closely, and to obtain a more exact and complete practical application of it, as I am doing in this account of the perfect harmony between socialism and Darwinism.

That is why, in the first edition of my *Socialism and Crime*, I held that the struggle for life is a law innate in humanity, as in all living beings, although it changes and is continually softened in its forms.

Such is still my view, against that of certain socialists who thought it better to meet this objection raised in the name of Darwinism by asserting that in humanity the "struggle for life" is a law which must lose all force and all application once the transformation socialism desires has been carried out. They thus set it down as a law which, tyrannical mistress of all beings from the microbe to the anthropoid ape, would have to die out and fall lifeless at the feet of man, as though he were not an inseparable link in the great biological chain.

I, on the contrary, held and hold that the struggle for life is a law inseparable from existence, and therefore from humanity; but that, while remaining always an immanent and continuous law, it goes on transforming itself in its content and softening in its forms.

In primitive humanity the struggle for life is scarcely to be distinguished from the struggle carried on by the other animals: it is the brutal struggle for daily food or for the female—hunger and love being the two fundamental needs and the two poles of life—and that struggle is waged with muscular force alone. In a later phase the struggle for political supremacy is added (in the clan, the tribe, the village, the commune, the state), and it is fought less and less with the muscles, more and more with the brain.

In the historical period, Greco-Latin humanity fights for *civil* equality (the abolition of slavery); it wins, but it does not rest, for life is struggle; the humanity of the Middle Ages fights for *religious* equality, and wins it, but does not stop; at the close of the last century it fights for *political* equality. And now humanity is fighting for *economic* equality, not in the sense of a material and absolute equality, but in the more positive sense I have explained above; and everything leads us to foresee, with mathematical certainty, that this struggle too will end, and give place to fresh conquests and to new ideals for those who come after us.

And along with the successive change in the meaning or in the ideals of the struggle for life goes the progressive softening of its methods, which from violent and muscular become more peaceful and intellectual, in spite of atavistic regressions or psychopathological manifes-

tations of personal violence by the individual against society and by society against the individual.

Upon this conception of mine—which has lately found a splendid demonstration in the remarkable work of Novicow, who nevertheless denies the sexual struggle—upon this conception, I say, I shall return at greater length in the chapter on the *Moral Future of Humanity*, in the second edition of *Socialism and Crime*.

For the present it is enough to add one further answer to the anti-socialist objection: not only does the disproportion between those born and those who survive grow constantly smaller, but the “struggle for life” itself changes its meaning and is softened in its forms at each successive phase of biological and social evolution.

Socialism may therefore very well maintain that the conditions of an existence fit for a man ought to be assured to all men—in exchange for the work given to the community—without on that account running foul of the Darwinian law of the survival of the victors in the struggle for life, a law that must be interpreted and applied exactly, in its various manifestations, to the progressive life of humanity, by comparison with humanity’s own primitive epochs and with the lower order of vegetable and animal life.

* * *

Besides, socialism itself, scientifically understood, does not prevent and cannot prevent there being always in humanity some who are vanquished in the struggle for life.

This argument bears more directly on the relations between socialism and crime, since it is precisely those who maintain that the struggle for life is a law that has lapsed for humanity who assert in consequence that *crime* (the abnormal and antisocial form of the struggle for life, as *work* is the normal and social form) must disappear from the earth; and hence a certain contradiction is thought to be found between socialism and the doctrines of criminal anthropology concerning the born criminal, which are likewise derived from Darwinism.

Reserving a fuller development of this question for another place, I may meanwhile sum up my view, as at once a criminal anthropologist and a socialist, in this way:

First of all, the positive criminal school deals with life as it is, and its merit is beyond dispute in having applied the experimental method to the study of the criminal phenomenon, deducing from it the absurdity and the hypocrisy of the present penal systems, which are based on the notion of free will and moral guilt and are carried out in prisons of the cellular system—which I have called and still call “one of the aberrations of the nineteenth century”—in order to replace them by the simple segregation of individuals unfit for social life through pathological conditions, congenital or acquired, permanent or temporary.

But to say that with socialism every form of crime will disappear is a statement prompted by a generous sentimental idealism, and not founded on rigorous scientific observation.

The positive criminal school shows that crime is a natural and social phenomenon—like insanity and suicide—determined by the abnormal organic and mental constitution of the criminal together with the influences of the physical environment and of the social environment. Anthropological, physical and social factors always work together, indissolubly, to determine any crime, from the slightest to the gravest—as is the case, in short, with every human act—only that for each criminal and for each crime the determining intensity of each order of factors is different.

For example: in a murder committed out of jealousy or under hallucination the most powerful action belongs to the anthropological factor, without our being able on that account to exclude the action of the physical and the social environment. On the other hand, in a crime against property, or even against persons, committed in the fury of a rioting crowd, or under alcoholism, and so forth, the greater intensity belongs to the social environment, without our being able on that account to exclude the influence of the physical environment and of the anthropological factor.

The same reasoning—to complete the examination of the anti-socialist objection made in the name of Darwinism—may be repeated for ordinary diseases, although crime for that matter belongs to human pathology as well.

Any disease, acute or chronic, infectious or not, grave or slight, is the resultant of the anthropological constitution of the individual and

of the influences of the physical and social environment. Only that in different diseases the determining intensity of the personal conditions or of the environment varies; consumption or heart disease, for instance, are diseases depending in very great part on the individual's organic constitution, though with the environment as an accomplice; but gout, or cholera, or typhus, or malarial cachexia and the like, depend on the contrary upon the social and physical conditions of the environment more than on anything else. That is why consumption makes havoc even among the well-to-do, who are therefore well fed and better housed, while cholera claims the greatest number of its victims among the ill-fed, that is, among the poor.

It is plain, then, that under the socialist regime of collective property, which assures to every man the conditions of an existence fit for a man, those diseases largely determined by the conditions of the environment and by insufficient food and shelter against the weather will greatly diminish and perhaps—with the help of continued scientific discovery and of progressive hygienic foresight—disappear; but diseases due to injury, insanity, pneumonia and the like will not disappear on that account.

The same must be said of crime: once poverty and the iniquitous inequalities of economic condition have been abolished, it is certain that through the direct removal of the spur of hunger, acute and chronic, through the indirect beneficial influence, physical and moral, of better feeding, and through the absence of occasions for abusing power or wealth, those crimes which are in great part occasional and which draw their chief determining intensity from the social environment will greatly diminish and will disappear. But there will not disappear, for instance, offenses against decency arising from pathological sexual inversion, or homicides due to epilepsy, or thefts due to psychopathological degeneration, and so on.

In the same way, under socialism popular education will become wider and deeper, illiterates will disappear, every talent will have the means of developing and establishing itself freely; but idiots and imbeciles from a hereditary pathological condition will not therefore disappear, even though a better economic and social organization, joined to the ever clearer guidance of experimental biology, and therefore to more frequent personal abstention from procreation in cases of hered-

itary disease, will also have a beneficial preventive and deterrent influence upon congenital degeneration (ordinary diseases, criminality, insanity, neuroses).

In conclusion, that is to say, even under the socialist regime—though in infinitely smaller proportion—there will always be those who are vanquished in the struggle for life, in the shape of the weak, the sick, the insane, the neurotic, the criminal, the suicide; and consequently socialism does not deny the Darwinian law.

But with this immense advantage, that the epidemic or endemic forms of human degeneration, physical and moral, will be completely suppressed by the removal of their chief source, which is the physical, and therefore the moral, misery of the many.

Thus, although the struggle for life goes on being the eternal driving force of social existence, it will unfold in forms ever less brutal and more human or intellectual, and for ideals ever higher, that is for physiological and mental improvement, on the fruitful basis of daily bread for the body and for the mind, assured to all men.

* * *

With regard to the “struggle for life,” we must not forget another law of natural and social Darwinism, to which certain socialists have given excessive and one-sided importance, while on the other hand many individualists have condemned it to a mistaken oblivion: I mean the law of solidarity among living beings of the same species, as among animals that live in society through the abundance of a common food supply (the herbivores), or even among different species, through the phenomenon that naturalists now call symbiosis, an agreement in living.

It is excessive to assert that in nature and in society the only law in force is the struggle for life, just as it is excessive to say that this law does not hold for humanity. The positive truth is that the struggle for life is an eternal law in the human world too, although it is softened in its forms and raised in its ideals; but beside it, and more than it, as a progressively effective determinant of social evolution, stands the law of solidarity or cooperation among living beings.

In animal societies themselves, mutual aid against adverse natural forces or against hostile living species has constant and ever more

marked manifestations, which develop further in the human species, beginning with the savage tribes themselves; and most of all in those tribes which, through favorable conditions of environment, that is through security and abundance of the means of subsistence, present the industrial or peaceful type of human society rather than the military or warlike type which too far predominates (precisely through insecurity and insufficiency of the means of life) in primitive humanity and in the phases of lesser or regressive civilization; although, as Spencer has shown, that type tends constantly to be replaced by the industrial type.

Hence, to keep to the human world, while in the dawn of social evolution the ascendancy belongs to the law of the struggle for life rather than to the law of solidarity, in proportion as the division of labor, and through it the mutual necessity of the parts, grows in the social organism, the struggle is softened and transformed, and the law of solidarity and cooperation acquires a sway progressively more intense and more extended. And all this, once again, for the fundamental reason pointed out by Karl Marx, which constitutes his true and great scientific discovery: namely, the security or insecurity of the conditions of existence, and first among them the security of food.

In the life of one individual, as in that of many individuals or of many societies, it may be verified that when the means of feeding, the physical basis of existence, are secure, the law of solidarity prevails over the law of struggle, and the reverse. Infanticide and parricide are held to be actions not merely lawful but obligatory in the savage world, if the tribe lives on islands where food is scarce (Polynesia and the like), and they become immoral and criminal actions on continents where food is more abundant and more certain. So too in the world of today, the want of security in daily bread for the greater part of mankind makes the manifestations of the struggle for life, or of "free competition" as the individualists call it, harsher and more brutal.

As soon as collective property assures to every man the conditions of existence, the law of solidarity will undoubtedly prevail.

What happens today on a small scale and by way of exception in the family, which, so long as its affairs go well and its daily bread is assured, is in perfect accord and ready for mutual kindness, only to let discord and strife come in the moment poverty shows itself, hap-

pens also on a large scale in society as a whole, and will happen as a constant rule under any better organization of the future.

Such will be the conquest, and such, I repeat, is the fullest and most fruitful interpretation that socialism must give to the inexorable natural laws discovered by Darwinism.

* * *

CHAPTER IV

THE SURVIVAL OF THE FITTEST

The third and last objection of the Haeckelian argument, while exact in its technically biological and Darwinian terms, has no foundation in the application that people would like to make of it in the social field against socialism.

It is said: the struggle for life secures the survival of the best and the fittest, and therefore follows an aristocratic procedure of individualist selection rather than the democratic collectivist leveling of socialism.

Let us begin, once again, by making quite clear what that famous natural selection, the undeniable fruit of the struggle for life, really consists in.

The phrase repeated by Haeckel and by so many others, "the survival of the best and the fittest," must be corrected by striking out the word *best*. It is a survival of that theology which admitted in nature and in history a final goal to be reached by way of continuous improvement.

Socialism, on the contrary, and still more the theory of universal evolution, has banished all *finalism* from modern thought and from the interpretation of natural phenomena: evolution takes in involution and dissolution as well. It may be, and it is, that in the final result, comparing the two extremes of humanity's road, we find that there really has been a powerful improvement; but in any case that improvement does not go in a straight ascending line, but rather, as Goethe says, follows a spiral, with partial rhythms of progress and regress, of evolution and dissolution.

Every cycle of evolution, in the life of the individual as in the life of the community, carries with it the germs of the corresponding cycle of dissolution; and conversely, out of the rotting of the exhausted

form new evolutions and new forms of life are prepared in the eternal laboratory.

That is why in the human social world each phase of civilization carries with it and always develops the germs of its own dissolution, out of which there evolves a new phase of civilization—shifting its geographical seat more or less—in the eternal rhythm of living humanity. The ancient hieratic civilizations of the East dissolve and rise again in the Greco-Roman world, afterward replaced by the feudal and aristocratic civilization of Central Europe, which, dissolved in its turn by the excesses it had reached, like the civilizations before it, is succeeded by bourgeois civilization, most highly developed in the Anglo-Saxon world. But this last already feels the chill of the fever of dissolution, while the socialist civilization is being born and evolving, and will spread over a larger part of the world than any of the civilizations before it.

* * *

It is not exact, then, to say that the natural selection determined by the struggle for life secures the survival of the *best*; the truth is that it secures the survival of the *fittest*.

And the difference is enormous, in natural Darwinism as in social.

Beyond doubt, the struggle for life determines the survival of the individuals best adapted to the environment and to the historical moment in which they live.

Now, in the natural biological field the free play of cosmic forces and conditions brings about precisely a raising of the forms of life, from the microbe to man.

In the human field, meanwhile, in what Spencer calls super-organic cooperation, the interference of other forces and other conditions sometimes brings about a selection in reverse, a dissolutive selection, which is still the survival of the *fittest* in a particular environment and at a particular historical moment, but which faithfully registers the vitiated conditions—where they are vitiated—of that same environment.

Such is the question of the “natural selections” which, on a first impression, some socialists and some who are not socialists likewise

interpret inexactly, so as to deny that Darwin's theories have any application at all to human society.

It is well known, in fact, how natural selection in civilized humanity has been vitiated by the concurrence of *military*, *marital* and above all *economic* selection.

The celibacy imposed today on soldiers plainly exerts a pernicious influence on the human race, because it leaves at home the weakest as the ones to procreate, while it exposes the healthiest young men to a temporary sterility and, in the great cities, to the dangers of syphilis, which is unhappily not so temporary.

So marriage too, injured as it is in the present civilization by economic interests, works as a general rule a sexual selection in reverse, because defective or degenerate women with a good dowry find husbands more easily than the more robust women of the people or of the middle class, who, being without a dowry, are condemned to sterile spinsterhood or to be lost in a prostitution more or less gilded.

In complex social life, then, the influence of present economic conditions is undeniable, conditions by which the monopoly of wealth secures its holders the victory in the struggle for life, so that the rich, though less robust, enjoy a longer existence than the ill-fed; while through the inhuman labor, by day and by night, imposed on adult men, and through the still more ruinous labor that modern capitalism imposes on women and children, the biological conditions of the great mass of the proletariat are more and more degraded.

To this must now be added moral selection in reverse, by which capitalism, in its struggle with the proletariat, favors the survival of the servile, while it persecutes and tries to stamp out men of character, who are less disposed to put up with the workings of the present economic organization.

The first impression produced by the verification of these facts leads people to deny that the Darwinian law of natural selection has any application or value whatever in the human world.

But I have held and hold that these social selections in reverse not only do not contradict the Darwinian law, but constitute a further argument in favor of socialism, which on this very side calls for, and will undoubtedly bring about, a more beneficial working of that same inexorable law of natural selection.

For the Darwinian law is not "the survival of the *best*"; it is only the survival of the "*fittest*."

Now it is plain that even the degenerative effects produced by social selection, and especially by the widest field of its continuous action, the present economic organization, confirm now and always the survival of those best adapted to this very economic order.

If the victors in the struggle for life are the worst and the weakest, that does not mean that the Darwinian law finds no application; it means only that the environment is vitiated, and that in it, therefore, those survive who are best adapted to it.

Just as in my studies of criminal psychology I have had to verify very often that in prisons or in the criminal world it is the fiercest or the most cunning offenders who come out victorious, precisely because they are the ones best *adapted* to that vitiated environment, so in modern economic individualism the man with fewest scruples wins, and the struggle for life favors whoever is best adapted to a world in which a man is worth what he has (no matter how he came by it) and not what he is.

The Darwinian law of selection works, then, in the human world too; and the error of those who deny it comes of confusing the present environment and historical moment (which takes the name of *bourgeois*, as that of the Middle Ages was called *feudal*) with the whole history of humanity, and of failing on that account to see that the undeniable and ruinous effects of the present social selection in reverse are nothing but a confirmation of the Darwinian law of the "survival of the *fittest*." Popular observation puts the fact in the proverb *la botte dà il vino che ha* (the cask gives the wine it has), and scientific observation explains it by the necessary biological relations between a given environment and the individuals that are born, struggle and survive in it.

But this is precisely a decisive argument in favor of socialism. Once the environment is rid of the vices that now foul it through unbri-dled economic individualism, the effects of natural and social selection will also necessarily be corrected. In an environment physically and morally sound, the individuals who are the fittest, and who therefore survive, will be sound as well.

Victory in the struggle for life will then be truly assured to whoever has the greater and more fruitful physical and moral energies,

and consequently the collectivist economic organization, by assuring every man the means of subsistence, must necessarily improve the human race in body and in mind.

* * *

But it is added: granted that socialism and Darwinian selection go together, is it not plain that the survival of the fittest constitutes an aristocratic individualist procedure that runs counter to socialist leveling?

We have the answer partly in the observation made above about the freedom that socialism assures to all individuals—and not merely to a few privileged or fortunate ones, as now—to establish and develop their own personality. The effect of the struggle for life will then truly be the survival of the best, precisely because in a normal environment victory is assured to the most normal individuals. And then social Darwinism will do nothing but continue natural Darwinism and make it more fruitful in benefits.

But on the other hand, and against the claim of an unlimited aristocratic selection, we must recall another natural law which completes that rhythm of actions and reactions on which the balance of life depends.

To the Darwinian law of natural inequalities must be added its correlative and inseparable companion, which after Morel, Lucas, Galton, De Candolle, Ribot, Spencer, Madame Royer, Lombroso and others was set in its clearest light by Jacoby.

The same nature that makes "selection" and aristocratic elevation a condition of vital progress at once restores the balance by a leveling and democratic law.

"Out of the human mass there arise individuals, families and races that tend to rise above the common level; they climb the steep heights, they reach the summit of power, of wealth, of intelligence, of genius, and once they have reached it they fall headlong and vanish into the abysses of insanity or of degeneration. Death is the great leveler; by annihilating all that rises, it makes humanity democratic."

Everything that tends to set up a monopoly of the natural forces runs against the supreme law of nature, which has given every living

thing the use and the disposal of the natural agents: air and light, as well as water and earth.

Everything that departs far below or far above the human average—which varies, rising from epoch to epoch, but which has an absolute value at each historical moment—is not long-lived, and dies out.

The cretin and the genius alike, the starveling and the millionaire, the dwarf and the giant, are natural or social monsters, and nature strikes them down inexorably with degeneration or with sterility. Aristocratic stocks, dynasties of sovereigns, families of artistic or scientific genius, the offspring of millionaires . . . all follow the common law, which confirms the inferences, egalitarian in this sense, of science and of socialism.

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CHAPTER V

SOCIALISM AND RELIGIOUS BELIEFS

None of the three alleged contradictions between Darwinism and socialism, then, asserted by Haeckel and repeated by so many others, will stand up to a calmer and more candid examination of the natural laws that take their name from Charles Darwin.

But I want to add that Darwinism not only does not contradict socialism, but is rather one of socialism's fundamental scientific premises; and further, as Virchow rightly saw, that socialism is on one side nothing but the logical and living offspring of Darwinism, just as on the other it is the offspring of Spencerian evolutionism.

* * *

Darwin's theory, like it or not, in proving that man is descended from the animals, has dealt a heavy blow to the belief in a God who created the universe and man by a special *fiat*. That is why the fiercest opposition, and the only opposition still surviving, against his fundamental inference has been and still is raised in the name of religion.

It is true that Darwin does not call himself an atheist, and that Spencer is not one; and strictly speaking, Darwin's theory and Spencer's alike can be reconciled with belief in God, since one may admit that God created matter and force, and that these afterward unfolded in successive forms, following the initial creative impulse. But it is undeniable, all the same, that these theories, which have made the idea of natural causation ever more rigid and universal, lead inevitably to the denial of God, because against that idea there always remains the question: And who created God?—And to the makeshift answer that God has always existed, the same answer is opposed,

namely that the universe has always existed.—As Ardigò observes, human thought cannot conceive that the chain running from effects to causes should stop at some conventionally chosen point.

God, as Laplace said, is a hypothesis that positive science has no need of and which, at most, according to Herzen, is an X summing up in itself, not the *unknowable*—as Spencer and Dubois-Reymond say—but everything *not yet known* by humanity. And it is therefore a variable X, which shrinks and retreats as the discoveries of science advance.

That is why science and religion move in inverse ratio, the one weakening and withering away just as far as the other extends and gathers strength in the struggle against the unknown.

Now, if this is one of the effects of Darwinism, its repercussion upon the growth of socialism is entirely plain.

Once faith is gone in a world beyond the grave, where the poor would be the elect of the Lord and the misery of this “vale of tears” would find eternal compensation in paradise, it is natural that the desire should revive for a little “earthly paradise” for the wretched and the less fortunate as well, who are the greater number on earth.

Outside socialism too, Hartmann and Guyau have noted that the evolution of religious beliefs proceeds in such a way that, while all religions carry in them the promise of happiness, the primitive ones allow that happiness to be realized in the life of the individual himself, from which the later ones, by excess of reaction, carried it beyond the grave, and in the final phase the realization of happiness is placed once more in human life, no longer in the brief instant of individual existence, but in the permanent evolution of humanity as a whole.

On this side too, then, socialism comes close to religious evolution and tends to take its place, because it wants humanity to have the “earthly paradise” in itself, without waiting for it in a *hereafter* which is, to say the least, highly problematical.

That is why many have remarked that the socialist movement has, for instance, many features resembling those of primitive Christianity, even in the ardor of faith shown by the man who has deserted the arid field of bourgeois skepticism: so much so that various men of science, some of them not socialists, such as Wallace, Laveleye, De Roberty and others, allow that socialism with its humanitarian faith may perfectly well replace the faith in a world beyond of the old religions.

But the most direct and effective relations are always, all the same, those between socialism and belief in God.

It is true that Marxist socialism, since the congress of the socialists at Erfurt (1891), rightly declares that religious beliefs are a matter for the private conscience, and that the socialist party therefore fights every form of religious intolerance, whether against Catholics or against Jews, as I too maintained in an article against *anti-Semitism*. But that loftiness of view is in substance nothing but the effect of certainty of final victory.

Precisely because socialism knows and foresees that religious beliefs—if not pathological phenomena of human psychology, as Sergi called them, then certainly useless phenomena of moral incrustation—are destined to wither away before the spread of scientific culture, however elementary; precisely for that reason socialism feels no need to make any special war upon those same religious beliefs, which are doomed to perish. And this although it knows that one of the most powerful forces working in its favor is precisely the absence or the weakening of belief in God, by means of which the priests of every religion and in every historical phase have been the strongest allies of the ruling classes, keeping the multitude subdued by religious fascination, like wild beasts under the tamer's whip.

That is why the more clear-sighted conservatives, atheists though they may be on their own account, lament that the religious sentiment—that most precious narcotic—is decaying among the masses, since they understand it, in a utilitarian and pharisaical way (though they do not say so), as an instrument of political domination.

Unhappily, however—or happily—the religious sentiment cannot be restored by decree of a king or of a president of a republic. It is dying out, through nobody's fault in particular and with no need of special propaganda, because it is in the air we breathe—an air charged with experimental scientific inferences—that it no longer finds the conditions of existence which it found so favorable in the mystical ignorance of past centuries.

And so the direct influence of modern positive science—which substitutes the notion of natural causation for that of the miracle and of the divinity—upon the extremely rapid growth and the experimental foundations of contemporary socialism is demonstrated.

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CHAPTER VI

THE INDIVIDUAL AND THE SPECIES

The second point that shows the direct descent of scientific socialism from Darwinism lies in the different way of conceiving the individual in relation to the species.

The eighteenth century closed with the exclusive glorification of the individual, of *man*—as an entity standing by himself—and in Rousseau's works this was nothing but a wholesome excess of reaction against the political and priestly tyrannies of the Middle Ages.

A direct consequence of this individualism is the political artificialism I shall deal with shortly, in studying the relations of the theory of evolution with socialism, and which is common alike to the rulers of the bourgeois system and to the individualist anarchists, since both believe that the social organization can be changed between one day and the next by the magic stroke of a clause in a statute or by the more or less murderous explosion of a bomb.

Modern biology, on the contrary, has radically altered this notion of the *individual*, and has shown in its own field and in that of sociology that on the one hand the individual is nothing but an assemblage of simpler vital elements, and on the other that the individual standing by himself (*Selbstwesen*, as the Germans would say) does not exist, but exists only in so far as he is part of a society (*Gliedwesen*).

All that lives is an association; a collectivity.

The *monad* itself, the living cell itself, which is the irreducible expression of biological individuality, is a compound of various parts, each of which is in turn composed of molecules, which are composed of atoms.

The atom alone exists as an individual, but the atom is invisible and impalpable, and the atom does not live.

All that lives is an association, a collectivity.

And as one rises through the zoological series up to man, the complexity of the compound, the federation of the parts, grows greater and greater.

For just as the metaphysics of individualism has its counterpart in Jacobin artificialism, which unifies and makes uniform, so the *positivity* of socialism has its counterpart in the idea of national and international federalism.

As the organism of a mammal is nothing but a federation of tissues, of organs, of systems, the organism of a society can only be a federation of communes, of provinces, of regions, and the organism of humanity a federation of nations.

And as it would be absurd to conceive a mammal that had to move, say, its head in uniform time with its limbs, and its limbs all together, so too it is absurd to have a political and administrative organization in which, for instance, the remotest province of the north or of the mountains must have the same bureaucratic machinery, the same network of laws, the same movements as the remotest province of the south or of the plain, for love of a symmetrical uniformity which is the pathological expression of unity.

Setting aside these political considerations—according to which, as I have said elsewhere, the only possible organization for Italy as for any other country seems to me to be political unity with administrative federalism—it is clear that at the close of the nineteenth century the individual as an entity standing by himself finds himself dethroned in the field of biology and in that of sociology.

The individual exists; but only in so far as he forms part of a social compound.

Robinson Crusoe—the genuine expression of individualism—can only be a legend or a pathological case.

The species—that is, the social compound—is the great, living and eternal reality of life, as socialism has shown and as all the positive sciences confirm, from astronomy to sociology.

Thus, while at the close of the eighteenth century Rousseau said that the individual alone exists, and that society is an artificial product of the “contract,” and added—attributing (as Aristotle had done before him in speaking of slavery) a permanent human character to the

passing manifestations of the historical moment of the old regime's decay in which he lived—that society was the cause of every evil, since all individuals were born good and equal; so, on the contrary, at the close of the nineteenth century all the positive sciences agree in saying that society, the compound, is a natural and unconquerable fact of life, in vegetable species as in animal, from the first “animal colonies” (the zoophytes) to the society of the mammals (the herbivores) and of man.

And everything best in the individual he owes precisely to social life, inasmuch as every phase of evolution is marked by pathological conditions and final conditions of social decay which are nevertheless essentially transitory and are the inevitable prelude to a new cycle of social renewal.

If the individual could live as an individual, he would live in obedience to only one of the two fundamental needs and instincts of existence: feeding—that is, the selfish preservation of his own organism by way of that primordial function which Aristotle already designated by the name of *ctesis*, the winning of food.

But every individual has to live in society, precisely because the second fundamental need and instinct of life is laid upon him, the reproduction of beings like himself for the preservation of the species; and it is out of that life of relation and reproduction (sexual and social) that the moral or social sense is born, by which the individual learns not only to *exist* but to *coexist* with his fellows.

It may be said, then, that these two fundamental instincts of life—bread and love—fill a function of social equilibrium in the life of animals, and especially in that of man.

Love is, for the greater number of men, the chief and earliest physiological outlet for the forces accumulated, in greater or lesser abundance, along with the daily bread, and saved up in the day's labor, or left untouched in parasitic idleness.

Love is the one enjoyment that is truly universal and egalitarian in character, so much so that the people call it “the paradise of the poor,” who are precisely the ones religion urges to enjoy it without any limit—*crescite et multiplicamini*—because erotic exhaustion, above all in the male, while it lessens or makes him forget the torments of work or of servile hunger, also saps the energy needed for steady organization, and therefore performs a function useful to the ruling class.

Nevertheless, just as this effect of the sexual instinct is inseparably matched by the other, the growth of population, so the immobilization of a given social order is thwarted precisely by the pressure of that population, which in our century is heightened by the characteristic phenomenon of the *proletariat*; and social evolution therefore goes forward, inexorable and inevitable.

To return to the argument: in any case it is undeniable that, while at the close of the eighteenth century it was believed that society was made for the individual—from which there might follow, as an unforeseen repercussion perhaps, that millions of men could and should live working and suffering for the benefit of a few individuals—at the close of our own century the positive sciences have shown that it is the individual who lives for the species, since the species alone is the eternal reality of life.

From which the whole tendency of modern scientific thought in the sociological or socialist direction stands out plainly, against the exaggerated individualism left as an inheritance by the last century.

It is true that biology shows we must not fall into the opposite extreme—into which certain schools of utopian socialism and of communism do fall—of afterward seeing nothing but society and forgetting the individual altogether. For it is another biological law that the existence of the compound is the resultant of the life of all the individuals, as the existence of an individual is the resultant of the life of the cells that compose him.

But in any case it is proved that the scientific socialism which marks the end of our century and will be the dawn of the twentieth is in perfect agreement with the direction of modern thought, even on the fundamental point of the predominance given to the vital demands of collective and social solidarity over the dogmatic exaggerations of individualism, which marked a powerful and fruitful awakening at the close of the last century, but which, by way of the pathological manifestations of unbridled competition, comes inevitably to the “libertarian” explosion of anarchism, that preaches individual action with complete forgetfulness of social and human solidarity.

And so we come to the last point of contact and of intimate connection between Darwinism and socialism.

CHAPTER VII

THE "STRUGGLE FOR LIFE" AND THE "CLASS STRUGGLE"

Darwinism has shown that the whole mechanism of animal evolution consists in the struggle for life between one individual and another of the same species on the one hand, and between species and species throughout the world of living things on the other.

In the same way the whole mechanism of social evolution was reduced by Marxist socialism to the law of the *class struggle*, concentrating on it not only attention, as the secret motive power and the one positive explanation of human history, but also the ideal and the strict rule of discipline of political socialism, thus withdrawing it from all the elastic, vaporous and inconclusive uncertainties of sentimental socialism.

The history of animal life found its positive explanation only in the great Darwinian law of the *struggle for life*—by which alone the natural causes of the birth, growth and extinction of vegetable and animal species, from the paleontological epochs to our own day, can be determined. In the same way the history of human life has found its explanation only in the great Marxist law of the *class struggle*, by which the annals of primitive, barbarous and civilized humanity cease to be a capricious and superficial kaleidoscope of individual episodes and become a drama determined, grandiose and inevitable—consciously or unconsciously, in the smallest details as in the most gigantic catastrophes—by the fatal motive power of the *economic conditions* that are the physical and therefore indispensable basis of life, and of the *class struggle* for the conquest and the keeping of that economic power on which all the others necessarily depend (political, juridical

and social power).

Of this grand conception, which constitutes the imperishable glory of Karl Marx—and gives him in sociology the place that Darwin holds in biology and Spencer in natural philosophy—I shall have occasion to speak further on, in tracing the relations between sociology and socialism.

For the present it is enough to point out another agreement between Darwinism and socialism, consisting in this: that while the phrase *class struggle* may make a first impression of distaste (which I confess I felt myself before I had grasped the scientific spirit of the Marxist theories), it holds nevertheless, in its true meaning, the first law of human history, and can therefore be by itself the sure rule for the coming of the new phase of human evolution that socialism foresees and hastens.

Class struggle means that human society, like any other living organism, is not a homogeneous whole, the undifferentiated sum of a greater or smaller number of individuals, but on the contrary a living organism resulting from the aggregation of parts that are different, and the more different the higher the degree of social evolution.

Just as a protozoon is composed of almost nothing but albuminous jelly, while a mammal is formed of tissues utterly unlike one another, so a headless tribe of the most primitive savages is composed only of a few families living in what is rather an aggregation of mere material neighborhood, while a privileged society of the historical or the contemporary world is composed of classes different from one another, whether in the physio-psychical constitution of the members themselves, or in the complexity of the habits and tendencies of their personal, family and social existence.

These different classes may be rigidly catalogued, as in ancient India from the *Brahmin* to the *Sudra*, and in medieval Europe too, from the emperor or the pontiff to the feudatory, the vassal, the artisan, in such a way that no exchange is allowed between one class and another of the individuals who belong to it by the mere accident of birth; or they may lose the legal label, as happens in Europe and America after the French Revolution, and so allow, as a rare exception, the exchange and passage of individuals from one class to another—like the chemical molecules in the phenomena of exosmosis and endosmosis, or,

in Dumont's phrase, by a phenomenon of "social capillarity." But always, in any case, these various classes exist as an undeniable reality, rebellious to any leveling on the juridical surface, since the fundamental reason for their variety persists.

It is Karl Marx who, more lucidly than anyone else, has pointed out that reason, verified it and confirmed it in the crucible of sociological observation: the difference of economic conditions.

The names, the appearances, the phenomena that echo them will vary in each phase of social evolution, but the tragic ground of human life will always lie in the contrast between those who hold the monopoly of the means of production—and they are the few—and those who, on the contrary, are dispossessed of them—and they are the many.

Warriors and herdsmen, in primitive society, as soon as the appropriation of the land, first by the family and then by the individual, had taken place under the original collectivism; *patricians and plebeians*; *feudal lords and vassals*; *nobles and commoners*; *bourgeois and proletarians* . . . all these are different names for one identical fact: the monopoly of wealth on one side, productive labor on the other.

Now, the great importance of the Marxist law—the class struggle—lies precisely in showing with evident precision *where* the vital point of the social question really lies, and *by what method* we may come to solve it.

So long as the economic basis of political, juridical and moral life was not established with positive evidence, the aspirations of the many toward a social improvement wandered uncertainly between the claim and the partial winning of some *accessory* instrument, such as freedom of worship, the political franchise, public education and so on. It is not denied that such conquests have been of great use.

But the *sancta sanctorum* remained forever impenetrable to the eyes of the multitude, and economic power, persisting as the privilege of the few, meant that any conquest or concession was built in the air, without roots, torn away from that solid and fruitful foundation which alone can give lasting life and strength.

Now that socialism—even before Marx, though not with such scientific precision—has pointed to individual appropriation, to private property in the land and in the means of production, as the vital point

of the question, now the problem stands before the conscience of contemporary humanity, precise, clear and inexorable.

* * *

What is the method of abolishing this monopoly of economic power and its consequent train of sorrows, of evils, of hatreds and of iniquity?

Here is the method of the *class struggle*, which, starting from the positive datum that every class tends to keep and increase the advantages and privileges it has won, teaches the class deprived of economic power that in order to obtain it the struggle (and we shall deal presently with the forms of this struggle) must be from class to class, not from person to person.

To hate, to insult, to make away with this or that individual belonging to the ruling class does not advance the solution of the problem by a single second, and indeed delays it through the reaction of common feeling against personal violence, since such violence offends the principle of *respect for the human person* which socialism proclaims aloud for all and against all. And it does not help toward the solution of the problem, because the present abnormal condition (which has grown more acute), the poverty of many and the comfort of a few, is not the effect of the ill will of this or that individual.

On this side too, in fact, socialism is in full and complete agreement with positive science, which denies free will in man and studies human activity, individual and collective, as an effect necessarily determined by the conditions of race and of environment.

Crime, suicide, insanity, poverty are not the fruit of free will, of individual guilt, as metaphysical spiritualism preaches; nor is it the fruit of free will or the individual guilt of the capitalist if the workman is badly paid, out of work, in want.

Every social phenomenon is the necessary resultant of historical conditions and of the environment; and in the modern world the ease and frequency of communication over every part of the earth has made the dependence of each fact—economic, political, juridical, moral, artistic or scientific—upon the most distant and most indirect conditions of universal life closer than ever.

Given the present organization of private property, with no limit on family inheritance and personal accumulation; given the continual and ever more complete application of scientific discovery to the human labor of transforming matter; given the telegraph and steam; given the ever more overflowing torrent of human migration, it is inevitable that the existence of a family of farm laborers, of workmen, of small tradesmen and the like should be bound by the invisible but inexorable threads of the life of the world, so that the cotton, coffee or wheat harvest in the most distant countries has its repercussions throughout the civilized world, just as the increase or decrease of sunspots is a coefficient of the periodic agricultural crises and bears directly on the fate of millions of men.

In this grand scientific conception of the “unity of the physical forces,” in Father Secchi’s phrase, or of universal solidarity, how can we still admit the mean and childish notion of free will and of the individual as the cause of human phenomena?

If a socialist took it into his head—even with charitable intent—to set up an industrial workshop to give work to the unemployed, and produced an article that fashion or the needs of general consumption had abandoned, he would plainly be obliged to fail, for all his philanthropic intentions, by the silent but inevitable decree of the economic laws.

Or if a socialist wished to give the workmen of his establishment double or treble the current wage, he would without any doubt meet the same fate, by the same inexorable working of the economic laws, because he would have to sell his goods at a loss, or keep them in his warehouses unsold so long as their price—quality being equal—stood above the market price.

He would be reduced to bankruptcy, and the world would give him no other consolation than to call him a *good man*, a phrase that in the present phase of “commercial morality” has a double meaning.

Apart, then, from the more or less cordial personal relations between capitalist and workman, their respective economic condition is inevitably determined by the law of *surplus labor*, by which Marx explains irrefutably how the capitalist can accumulate wealth without working, simply because in every working day the workman produces an equivalent of wealth greater than the wage he receives, an excess

of product which naturally goes as a free gain to the capitalist, even if we choose to deduct from it the wage of his own intellectual labor of technical and administrative direction.

Land left to the sun and the rain produces neither wheat nor wine of itself. Minerals do not come out of the bowels of the earth by themselves.

The production of wealth takes place only through a transformation of matter worked upon by human labor. And only because the peasant cultivates the land, the miner brings up the ore, the workman drives the machines, the chemist makes experiments in his laboratory, the engineer invents and so forth, can the landowner or the capitalist, having done nothing to inherit his patrimony, and without any exertion at all if he remains an *absentee* from his property, be assured every year of a product which others produce for him in exchange for scanty bread and wretched housing, poisoned more often than not by the miasmas of the rice fields or the marshes, by the gas of the mines or the workshops, and never attaining an existence worthy of human creatures.

And even under the system of perfect *métayage*—which is held up as a formula of practical socialism—it still remains to be asked by what miracle the landowner, who does not work, sees wheat, oil and wine arrive at his house in quantity sufficient to live in comfort, while the *métayer* gives his labor every day to wring from Mother Earth food for himself and for others.

What is least painful in *métayage* is the quiet certainty of reaching the year's end without the convulsions of unemployment to which the casual laborers of country and town are condemned. But in substance the problem remains unaltered, and there is always one man who lives well without working because ten live badly by working.

Such is the machinery of private property, and such are its effects, outside and against the very will of individuals.

Thus every attempt against this or that individual turns out empty and sterile: what must be changed is the orientation of society; what must be abolished is individual property, not by *sharing out*, as people commonly say, which would be a sharper and meaner form of private property, since a year later, that individualist orientation persisting, we should be back at the *status quo*, to the sole benefit of the craftiest and the least scrupulous.

What is needed is the abolition of private or individual property, and its replacement by the collective and social property of the land and of the means of production; a substitution which, while it cannot be made by decree between one day and the next, as some accuse us of wishing, is being carried out day by day and hour by hour, both directly and indirectly.

Directly: because civilization shows a continual substitution of social property and social functions for what were formerly individual property and individual functions. Roads, the posts, the railways, museums, street lighting, education and the rest, which only a few decades ago were private property or private functions, have become social property or social functions; and it would be absurd to think that this direct process of socialization must stop precisely now, instead of speeding up progressively, as everything in modern life is speeding up.

Indirectly: as the final effect of that economic individualism which took the name of *bourgeois*, from the sturdy townsmen who in the Middle Ages lived in the boroughs subject to the feudal castle and the parish church—symbols of the class then dominant—and who, prepared by fruitful and conscious labor and by the historical conditions that changed the economic orientation of the world (such as the discovery of America), made their revolution at the close of the eighteenth century, winning power by it and writing pages of gold in the history of the civilized world with national epics and with the miracles of science applied to industry . . . but who now describe the descending curve and show plain symptoms of a dissolution without which, for that matter, the opening of a new social phase would not be possible.

Economic individualism, carried to its ultimate consequences, necessarily brings about the progressive centralization of property in an ever narrower circle of persons. "Millionaire" is a new word, peculiar to the nineteenth century, and it expresses in more evident proportions that phenomenon which George reduced to the historical law of economic individualism, by which the rich grow ever richer and the poor poorer.

Now, it is plain that the narrower the number of those who hold the land and the means of production, the easier their replacement

becomes—with or without personal compensation—by a single proprietor which is society, and which can be nothing else.

The land is the physical basis of the social organism. It is therefore absurd that it should belong to a few individuals and not to the whole social community, as it would be absurd that the air we breathe should belong to the monopoly of a few proprietors.

And this is the supreme aim of socialism.

But it is plain that we cannot get there by taking this or that proprietor, this or that capitalist, as our mark.

That too is an individualist means of struggle, doomed to remain sterile, or at any rate demanding an immense scattering of forces for scanty, partial and provisional results.

That is why, when I see political men wearing themselves out in daily or anecdotal protests, in a struggle of persons—to which, for that matter, assemblies and the public grow accustomed and resigned by its very monotonous continuity—I seem to be looking at some extravagant sanitarian who would make a marsh habitable by shooting the mosquitoes one by one, instead of setting himself, as method and as object, the complete draining of the whole miasmatic zone . . .

No personal struggles or personal violence, then! Class struggle, in the sense of giving to the immense class of the workers of every trade and profession the consciousness of these fundamental truths and therefore of their own class interests, set against the interests of the class that keeps economic power, so as to come by conscious organization to the conquest of that economic power, through the other public powers which present civilization has secured to free peoples.

Though it may be foreseen that the ruling class in every country will, before yielding, restrict those public liberties which were harmless to it so long as they were used by workers not organized as a class party, but distracted or hypnotized in the following of other political parties, as radical on accessory questions as they are profoundly conservative on the fundamental question of economic organization and of property.

Class struggle, then. Struggle of class against class.

And struggle, be it understood, by the methods of which I shall speak presently, in dealing with the four modes of social transformation: evolution, revolution, rebellion, personal violence.

But meanwhile, class struggle in the Darwinian sense, the grand drama of the struggle for life between species and species repeating itself in human history, without sinking into the savage and insignificant fisticuffs of individual against individual.

* * *

Let us stop at this point, though the same argument of the relations between Darwinism and socialism might be carried further, always in the sense of removing every alleged contradiction between the one and the other current of modern scientific thought, and of confirming, on the contrary, the closest, most natural and most indissoluble agreement between them.

Virchow's keen foresight answers exactly, therefore, to the historical parallel of Johann Jacoby.

"In the same year in which Darwin's book appeared (1859), from an entirely different direction toward the same goal, a most important development of social science was set going by a work that remained long unknown, a work entitled *Critique of Political Economy*, by Karl Marx, which was the forerunner of *Capital*.

"What Darwin's book on the *Origin of Species* is for the genesis and evolution of unconscious nature up to man, the work of Marx is for the genesis and evolution of the community of human individuals, of nations and of the social forms of humanity."

And that is why contemporary Germany, which has been the most fruitful field for the development of the Darwinian theories, is also the most fruitful field for the conscious, disciplined and unshakable propaganda of socialist ideas.

And that, precisely, is why in Berlin, in the windows of the bookshops of socialist propaganda, the works of Charles Darwin have their place of honor beside those of Karl Marx.

PART TWO



EVOLUTION AND SOCIALISM

INTRODUCTION

Even in the face of the theory of universal evolution, which—apart from this or that more or less debatable detail—truly represents the vital direction of modern scientific thought, people have thought it reasonable to assert that it contradicts in substance the theories and the practical ideals of socialism.

But here the mistake is plain.

If by socialism we mean that fluctuating tangle of sentimental aspirations which has so often crystallized into utopian artificial creations of a new human world, destined by a stroke of the magic wand to replace overnight the old world we live in, then it is perfectly true that the scientific theory of evolution condemns the prejudices and the illusions of political artificialism, whether reactionary or revolutionary, but romantic in either case.

The misfortune of our adversaries, however, is that present-day socialism is very different from the socialism that came before Marx's work; and apart from the animating sentiment of protest against present iniquities and of aspiration toward a better future, it has nothing in common with the older socialism in its logical structure or in its inferences, except the clear and mathematically exact vision (by virtue precisely of the theories of evolution) of the final social organization, based on collective property in the land and in the means of production.

This will become evident in the examination of the three chief alleged contradictions said to exist between socialism and scientific evolutionism.

Meanwhile it is impossible not to see, even now, the direct descent of Marxist socialism from scientific evolutionism as well, when we con-

sider that it is nothing but the logical and consistent application of the evolutionist theory in the economic field.

* * *

CHAPTER VIII

THE ORTHODOX THESIS AND THE SOCIALIST THESIS IN THE FACE OF THE THEORY OF EVOLUTION

In sum, what does socialism say? That the present economic world cannot be unchangeable and eternal, but on the contrary represents a transitory phase of social evolution, which must be followed by a later phase and by a differently organized world.

That this coming organization is to be realized in a collectivist or socialist sense—rather than in an individualist one—is the final and positive conclusion that follows from the study already made of the relations between Darwinism and socialism.

Meanwhile it must be established here that this fundamental assertion of socialism—apart from the details of the future social organization, of which I shall speak later—is consistent with the experimental theory of evolutionism.

What, then, is the substantial contradiction between orthodox political economy and socialism? This: that political economy has maintained and still maintains that the economic laws it analyzes and expounds concerning the production and distribution of wealth are *natural laws* . . . not, however, in the sense of laws naturally determined by the conditions of the social organism (which would be exact), but in the sense that they are *absolute laws*, that is, laws belonging to all humanity in every time and place, and consequently unchangeable in their main points, though open to partial and accessory modification in their details.

Scientific socialism maintains, on the contrary, that the laws laid down by classical political economy, from Adam Smith onward, are laws belonging to the present historical moment of civilized human-

ity, and that they are therefore laws essentially *relative* to the moment in which they were analyzed; and since they no longer answer to the reality of things if we try to extend them, for instance, to remote historical antiquity, and still less to prehistoric times, they cannot represent an unchangeable petrification of the social future.

Now, of these two fundamental theses, the orthodox and the socialist, which is the more in keeping with the scientific theory of universal evolution?

The answer is not in doubt.

The theory of evolution—whose true and original creator was Herbert Spencer—by developing and making fruitful on sociological ground the relativist direction already marked out by the historical school, in law as well as in political economy (which was partly heterodox), has given human thought this indispensable compass: that everything changes; that the present—in the astronomical order as in the biological and the sociological—is nothing but the resultant of preceding transformations, natural, necessary and unceasing, stretching over thousands upon thousands of years; and that consequently, just as the present is unlike the past, so the future will beyond any doubt be unlike the present.

Spencerism has thus done nothing but furnish a truly marvelous store of scientific proofs, in every branch of human knowledge, for the two abstract thoughts of Leibniz and of Hegel, that “the present is the child of the past but the father of the future,” and that “Nothing is, but everything becomes”; which geology above all, from Lyell onward, had demonstrated marvelously, substituting for the traditional notion of unforeseen cataclysms the scientific notion of the gradual and daily transformation of the earth.

It is true that Herbert Spencer’s encyclopedic learning is deficient in political economy, or at least that in that field he has not given proofs as complete as in the natural sciences; but this does not prevent socialism from being, after all, nothing else, in the idea that animates it, than the logical application of the scientific theory of natural evolution to the order of economic phenomena.

It is precisely for this reason that Karl Marx, first (in 1859) with the *Critique of Political Economy* (and also with the famous *Manifesto* of 1847, written by him and Engels almost ten years before Spencer’s *First*

Principles, and marvelous for its power and its lucidity of synthesis) and afterward with *Capital* (1867), completed in the social field the scientific revolution brought about by Darwin and Spencer.

While the old metaphysical thought conceived morals, law and economics as the combination of absolute and eternal laws, after the Platonic manner of thinking, and, limiting its observation to the historical world and using no instrument of inquiry but the logical fancy of the philosopher, inoculated in the brains of so many generations that notion of the absolutism of natural laws, struggling all the while in the dualism of matter and spirit; positive science, on the contrary, arriving at the grand synthesis of *monism*, that is, of the one phenomenal reality—matter and force, inseparable and indestructible—unfolding continuously, from form to form, by rules relative to time and place, has radically changed the direction of modern thought precisely in the sense of universal evolution.

Morals, law, politics are nothing but superstructures of the economic structure rather than repairs of it, and they vary with it from one parallel of latitude to another, from one century to the next.

This is the great and brilliant intuition of Karl Marx in the *Critique of Political Economy*, of which I shall examine later the part relating to the single source of economic conditions, but of which what matters now is the point concerning its continual and unrestrainable changeability, from the prehistoric world to the historical world and through the various epochs of the latter.

Rules of morality, religious beliefs, the juridical sanctions of civil or penal laws, political organization, everything changes and everything stands in relation to the historical and physical environment in which it is observed.

To murder one's parents is the greatest of crimes in Europe and America; to kill them is, on the contrary, an obligatory act, sanctified by religion, on the island of Sumatra, just as cannibalism is lawful in central Africa and was lawful in prehistoric Europe and America.

The family, which is barely formed, and then only for a time (as among animals), under primitive sexual communism, organizes itself in polyandry and the *matriarchate* where scanty food requires a scanty increase of population, but passes to polygamy and the patriarchate where that fundamental economic reason does not tyrannically

prevail, in order at last to take on, in the historical world, the monogamous form which is beyond doubt the best and the most advanced, even though it needs to be freed from the absolutist conventionality of the indissoluble tie and from the disguised and legalized prostitution (for economic reasons) that stain it in the world of today.

And is the constitution of property alone to go on eternal and unchangeable amid this oceanic current of social institutions and moral rules, subject as they are to continual and profound evolutions and transformations?

Is property alone to remain undisturbed and unaltered in its form of private monopoly of the land and of the means of production! . . .

Such is the absurd pretension of economic and juridical orthodoxy, whose one concession to the irresistible verifications of the evolutionist theory (a concession made by the progressives or radicals in science as in politics) is that property's accessory ornaments may be varied and its *abuses* tempered, while the principle always remains untouched that a few individuals may appropriate the land and the instruments of production necessary to the life of every social organism, which would thus remain forever under the more or less eternal dominion of those who hold the physical basis of life.

It is enough to set out the two fundamental theses in this way, in their clear precision—the orthodox thesis of law and of practical economics and the heterodox thesis of economic and scientific socialism—to settle this first point of controversy without further argument: that in every case the theory of evolution is in perfect and irrefutable agreement with the inferences of socialism, while on the contrary it contradicts the opposing assertions of economic and juridical *immobilism*.

* * *

CHAPTER IX

THE LAW OF APPARENT REGRESSION AND COLLECTIVE PROPERTY

But—say our adversaries—even granting that socialism, in calling for a social transformation, is apparently in agreement with the evolutionist theory, it does not follow that its more precise conclusions—among which stands the fundamental one of substituting social property for individual property—are supported by that same theory. We maintain, on the contrary—so the argument runs—that those conclusions run diametrically counter to that scientific theory, and are consequently, to say the least, utopian and absurd.

And the first contradiction alleged between socialism and evolutionism would be that the return to collective property in the land would be at the same time a return to the primitive and savage ages of humanity, and that socialism would therefore indeed be a transformation, but a transformation in reverse; that is, against the current of social evolution, which from the primitive collectivism of the land has arrived at the present individual property, the mark of advanced civilization. Socialism, in that case, would represent a step back into barbarism.

This objection too has a share of truth in it which is undeniable: the assertion that collective property will be (at least in outward appearance) a return toward the primitive social organization. But the conclusion drawn from it is absolutely mistaken and unscientific, because it leaves out of account a law less commonly observed but not for that reason less true or less positive than social evolution itself.

It is a sociological law which a very ingenious French physician, now unhappily dead (Dramard), did no more than point out in con-

nection with certain affinities between transformism and socialism, and with which I dealt, acknowledging all its truth and importance even before I enrolled myself in militant socialism, on pages 420-424 of the third edition of my *Criminal Sociology* (1892), and on which I insisted again in my controversy with Morselli on the subject of divorce.

This law of apparent regression shows that the return of social institutions to their primitive forms and characters is a constant fact.

Before giving some clear examples, I want to point out that Cognetti De Martiis, as early as 1881, showed that he knew this sociological law intuitively and in a vague way, since his book on the *Primitive Forms in Economic Evolution* (Turin, 1881), so remarkable for the abundance, precision and soundness of its positive data—though it reached no conclusion at all after all the wealth of its sociological analysis—closed in its last lines with a vague reference to the possible reappearance, in the future economic evolution, of the primitive forms that mark the starting point.

I recall too that when I attended Carducci's lectures at the university of Bologna I several times heard him point out that in the forms and in the substance of literature the latest progress is often nothing but a reproduction of the substance and the forms of primitive Greco-Oriental literature; just as, in short, the modern theory of monism, which is the very soul of universal evolution and represents the last and definitive positive discipline of human thought before the reality of the world, after the brilliant wanderings of metaphysics, does nothing but return to the notions of the Greek philosophers and of Lucretius, the great naturalist poet.

But in the order of social institutions too the examples of this return to primitive forms are all too evident and all too numerous.

I have already spoken of religious evolution according to Hartmann, by which in the childhood epochs of humanity happiness was thought attainable in individual existence, afterward in the life beyond the grave, and now tends to be placed once more in humanity itself, but in the series of generations to come.

So Spencer (*Sociology*, III, chapter V) pointed out that in politics the will of all—the sovereign element in primitive humanity—yields its place step by step to the will of one, and next of a few (by way of various aristocracies: of arms, of birth, of profession, of money), and

tends at last to become sovereign again by the methods of democracy (universal suffrage, the referendum, direct popular legislation and so forth).

The right to punish, a simple function of defense in primitive humanity, tends to become such once more, shaking off every theological pretension of retributive justice, a pretension superimposed by the illusion of free will upon the natural ground of defense, but now stripped away by the characteristic observations on crime as a natural and social phenomenon, which show that the omniscient pretension of the legislator or the judge to weigh and measure the "guilt" of the offender and to balance the punishment against it is absurd and impossible, instead of confining himself to segregating from civil society, temporarily or permanently, the individuals unfit for it, as is done with the insane or with those attacked by infectious diseases.

With marriage the same thing has happened: its easy dissolution in primitive humanity gave way little by little to the absolute demands of theology and spiritualism, which believe that "free will" can bind a person's destiny forever by a monosyllable pronounced at a moment of such unstable mental equilibrium as the time of betrothal and wedding. But afterward the return to the spontaneous and primitive form of consent forces itself on us, and the marriage union, with the ever wider and ever easier use of divorce, comes back to its origins, making sound again the family, which is the social cell.

So it is too with the organization of society, in which Spencer himself has had to recognize the inevitable tendency toward a return to primitive collectivism, now that the appropriation of the land, first by the family and then by the individual—as he himself has shown—has reached its furthest extremes, so much so that in some countries (the *Torrens* act) the land has become a kind of movable property, transferable like any share in any joint stock company.

Here, by way of documentation, is what the *individualist* Spencer writes:

"At first sight it might seem that the absolute ownership of land by private persons must be the *final* state which industrialism is destined to bring about. Nevertheless, although industrialism has thus far had the effect of individualizing all such property, *it may be questioned whether the final state has yet been reached.*

"There was a time when rights of property in human beings were acknowledged, and now they are no longer admitted. Some centuries ago it might have been thought that the principle of the ownership of man by man was on the way to being *definitively* established. Nevertheless, at a more advanced stage of its course, civilization, by overthrowing that arrangement, has destroyed the ownership of man by man. In like manner, at a stage more advanced still, it may come about that *private property in land will have to disappear.*"

And besides, this process of socializing property, partial and accessory though it now is, is nevertheless so evident and so continuous that it would be to deny the undeniable to maintain that the economic, and therefore the juridical, direction of the organization of property is not moving toward an ever greater preponderance of the interests and rights of the community over those of the individual; a preponderance which will evidently become, by an inevitable evolution, a complete substitution as regards the ownership of the land and of the means of production.

* * *

So then, we repeat, the fundamental thesis of socialism goes in perfect agreement with that sociological law of apparent regression, whose natural grounds Loria pointed out very well when he said that primitive humanity draws from its first impressions of the surrounding natural world the fundamental and simplest lines of its thought and its life; afterward, with the progress of intelligence and the increasing complication that the law of evolution brings, there comes an analytical development of the chief elements contained in the first germs of any institution; and once this analytical and often antagonistic development of the particular elements has been carried out, from one extreme to the other, humanity itself, having reached a high degree of evolution, recomposes those various elements in a final synthesis, and returns to the primitive starting point.

To this, however, I would add that this return to the primitive form is not a pure and simple repetition. That is why it is called the law of *apparent* regression, and that is why the objection of a "step back into primitive *barbarism*" is groundless. It is not a pure and simple repetition, but the completion of a cycle, of a great rhythm—as Asturaro

too was lately saying—which cannot fail to carry with it the effects and the conquests, irrevocable in all that is vital and fruitful in them, of the long evolution that went before; and it is therefore far superior, in objective reality and in human consciousness, to that primitive embryo.

The course of social evolution is not represented by the closed circle which, like the serpent biting its own tail in the old symbol, shuts off the terms of a better future; on the contrary, and according to Goethe's image, it is figured by a spiral which seems to turn back upon itself and which in fact advances and rises without ceasing.

* * *

CHAPTER X

SOCIAL EVOLUTION AND INDIVIDUAL LIBERTY

This last observation serves here for the examination of the second contradiction said to exist between socialism and the theory of evolution, when it is said and repeated in every key that socialism will be a new form of tyranny and will do away with all the benefits of the liberty so laboriously won by our century at the cost of so much martyrdom and sacrifice.

I have already said, in speaking of anthropological inequalities, how socialism will on the contrary assure every man the conditions of a human existence and the freest and fullest basis for his own personality.

Here it is enough for me to recall another law, established by the scientific theory of evolution, in order to show in a general way (for it is not the business of this essay to go into small details) how that alleged suppression of the living and fruitful part of personal and political liberty is wrongly taken as a consequence of the coming of socialism.

The following is a law of natural evolution set forth by Ardigò better than by anyone else:

Every succeeding phase of natural and social evolution does not destroy or blot out the vital and fruitful manifestations of the preceding phases, but carries them on in whatever is vital in them, while eliminating their aberrant or pathological manifestations.

In biological evolution the manifestations of vegetable life do not blot out the first faint beginnings of life to be found in the crystallization of minerals, just as the manifestations of animal life do not blot out those of mineral and vegetable life; and the human form of life does not blot out the earlier forms and links of the great series of liv-

ing things, but on the contrary the later forms live precisely because they are the outcome of the primitive forms, and coexist with them.

So it is in social evolution: and this is exactly the interpretation that scientific evolutionism gives of the Middle Ages, which do not blot out the conquests of earlier civilizations but preserve them on the contrary in their vital part, and make them fruitful in a period of repose for the rebirth of new civilizations.

And this law, which governs the whole grand development of social life, governs equally the destiny and the curve of every social institution.

The succession of one phase of social evolution to another does indeed eliminate the non-vital parts, the pathological products of the earlier institutions; but it preserves, strengthens and develops the sound and fruitful parts, raising higher and higher the physical and moral level of humanity.

Thus, by this natural process, the great river of humanity, issuing from the virgin forests of savage life, has spread out majestically through the periods of barbarism and into the present civilization, which is beyond doubt superior in many respects to the preceding phases of social life, but which in others is poisoned by the virulent products of its own degeneration, as I have recalled in speaking of social selection in reverse.

Thus, for instance, it is true that the workers of the present period of bourgeois civilization have on the whole a physical and moral existence superior to that of past centuries; but it is nonetheless undeniable that their economic condition as *free wage earners* is in many respects worse than the earlier condition of *slaves* in antiquity and of *serfs* in the Middle Ages.

For the ancient *slave* was the absolute property of his master, of the *free* man, and was condemned to a life that was almost that of a beast; but meanwhile the master had at least an interest in securing him his daily bread, since the slave formed part of his patrimony, like his oxen and his horses.

And the serf of the glebe in the Middle Ages had by way of compensation certain customary rights that rooted him to the land and assured him, at the very least—except in times of scarcity—his daily bread.

The free wage earner of the modern world, on the contrary, is always condemned to a labor inhuman in its length and in its kind (and it is to this that we owe the partial socialist claim of the *eight hours*, which can already count many victories and is destined to certain triumph); but having no permanent juridical relation either with the capitalist proprietor or with the land, he has no security whatever of his daily bread, because the proprietor no longer has an interest in feeding and maintaining the workers of his factory or of his fields, since his patrimony suffers no loss either by their death or by their illness, thanks to the inexhaustible supply of proletarians that lack of work offers him in the market.

And so it comes about—not because the proprietors of today are more wicked than those of antiquity, but only because moral sentiments too are products of economic condition—that if an ox falls sick in the stall, the proprietor or his steward sends for the veterinary at once, to avoid the loss of capital; whereas if the oxherd's child falls sick there is less hurry about sending for the doctor.

It is true that there may be, as an exception more or less frequent, a kind-hearted proprietor who gives the lie to this rule, especially when he lives in daily contact with the workers; just as it is not denied that the spirit of charity has frequent and more or less noisy manifestations—even apart from the *charity sport*—on the part of the wealthy classes, who thus also soothe the inward voice of the moral uneasiness that invades them. But the inexorable rule is this: under the form of modern industrialism the worker has won political liberty, of the vote, of association and the rest (which he is allowed to enjoy so long as he does not show that he is using it to form a class party that makes for the substantial point of the social question), but he has lost the security of his daily bread and his daily roof.

Socialism wants to reach that security for all men—and it shows its mathematical positivism in the substitution of social for individual property in the means of production—but socialism is not on that account to suppress all the useful and really fruitful conquests of the present phase of civilization and of those before it.

Take a characteristic example: the invention of so many industrial and agricultural machines, which is a brilliant application of science to the transformation of natural forces, and which therefore ought to

be nothing but fruitful in benefits—raising labor from the abjection and prostration of brutish toil to human dignity—has nevertheless brought and still brings poverty and ruin upon thousands of workers who, through the reduction of hands replaced by the work of machines, are inevitably condemned to the torments of unemployment, or to the iron law of the minimum wage, which barely suffices to keep them from dying of sheer hunger.

And the first instinctive reaction of these unfortunates has been and in many cases still is to destroy the machines, cursing them as an instrument of undeserved and bloody ruin.

But to destroy the machines would really be a pure and simple step back into barbarism, and socialism does not want that, socialism which represents a higher phase of human civilization.

And so it is that socialism alone gives to this painful difficulty a solution that economic individualism cannot give, since individualism goes on applying new machines forever, such being the irresistible tendency of the capitalist.

And the solution is that the machines should become collective or social property. Then it is plain that their only effect will be to lessen the total sum of work and of muscular effort needed to produce a given quantity of articles, and consequently each workman's daily share of labor will be lessened, and his existence will rise more and more to the dignity of a human creature.

This effect is already produced in part, for instance, in those places where several small proprietors join in a society to buy a steam threshing machine and lend it out among themselves by turns. If the workmen and the farm laborers were also joined to the small proprietors in a great and brotherly cooperation (and this would happen only when the land was social property), and if the machines were, say, municipal property, as the fire engines are, and were lent out for the successive tasks of the countryside, it is plain that those machines would produce no painful repercussion and no poverty, but would be blessed by all men, for the mere fact of being collective property.

Since socialism represents a higher phase of human evolution, it would therefore eliminate from the present phase only the infectious products of the excessive economic individualism of today, which creates on one side the millionaires, or the contractors who become millionaires in a few years by stealing the public money—in a form more

or less provided for by the Penal Code—and on the other side forms a gangrenous heap of wretched creatures in the foul garrets of the great cities, or in the huts of straw and mud that copy the Australian huts in Basilicata, in the Roman Campagna and in the valley of the Po.

No conscious socialist has ever dreamed of denying the great services of the bourgeoisie to human civilization, or of tarnishing the pages of gold it has written in the history of the civilized world with the national epics and the marvelous applications of science to industry and to intellectual and commercial exchange among peoples.

These are irrevocable conquests of human progress, and socialism does not dream of disowning them or of suppressing them, and pays a just and grateful admiration to the generous *pioneers* who began them and carried them out. In the same way, for instance, it would no more dream of destroying, or of refusing its admiration to, a painting by Raphael or a statue by Michelangelo, merely because these men transfigured and made eternal in art the legends of religion.

But socialism sees in the present bourgeois civilization, now on its final downward slope, the painful symptoms of an irremediable dissolution, and affirms that the social organism must be freed of the infectious *virus*, not by confining ourselves to the symptomatic and individualist cure of this or that bankrupt, this or that corrupt official, this or that thieving contractor . . . but by going to the root of the evil, to the undeniable source of the virulent infection. By radically changing the system—with the substitution of social for individual property—the sound and vital forces of human society must be renewed, so that it may rise to a higher phase of civilization, in which a few privileged persons will no longer be able to live the life of idleness, of luxury, of debauch that they live today, and will have to submit to a laborious and more modest existence, but in which the immense majority of men will raise their own to serene dignity, quiet security, kindly and cheerful brotherhood, in place of the sorrows, the anxieties, the rancors of the present.

* * *

So much for the banal objection that socialism will suppress all liberty, an objection too often repeated by those who, under the cloak of

political liberalism, conceal the more or less conscious tendencies of economic conservatism.

This repugnance that many feel in the name of liberty—even in good faith—is nothing but the effect of another law of human evolution, which Herbert Spencer formulated by saying: every progress achieved is an obstacle to the progress to come.

It is a natural psychological tendency, which might be called fetishistic, that refuses to regard the ideal attained and the progress achieved as a simple instrument rather than as an idol, and to take them as a starting point for other ideals and other advances rather than to halt in fetishistic adoration of a point of arrival that exhausts every other ideal and every other aspiration.

Just as the savage who has profited by the fruit tree adores the tree for itself, not for the fruits it may still give him, and turns it into a fetish, an untouchable idol, but one that for that very reason becomes barren; just as the miser, who in the individualist world knows the value of money, ends by adoring money in and for itself, as a fetish and an idol, and leaves it buried in his chest, making it barren, instead of using it as an instrument of fresh gains; so the sincere liberal, child of the French Revolution, makes of liberty an idol, an end in itself, a sterile fetish, instead of employing it as an instrument of fresh conquests, as a means of realizing new ideals.

It is understandable that under political tyranny the first ideal, the most urgent, the feverish one, should have been the winning of liberty and of political sovereignty.

And we latecomers are grateful for that conquest to the martyrs and the heroes who willed it at the price of their blood.

But liberty is not and cannot be an end in itself!

What is the use of freedom of assembly and of thought if the stomach has not its daily bread and millions of individuals have every moral force paralyzed by the anemia of body and brain?

What is the use to the people of a platonic share in political sovereignty through the right to vote, if it goes on under the material slavery of poverty, of unemployment, of hunger acute or chronic?

Liberty for liberty's sake marks a progress achieved which sets itself against the progress to come, and is a kind of political onanism, barren in itself in the face of the new needs of life.

Socialism therefore answers that, just as the succeeding phase does not blot out the conquests of the preceding phases of social evolution, so neither does it wish to suppress the liberty gloriously won by the bourgeois world in its revolution of 1789; on the contrary it wishes that the workers, having won consciousness of the interests and needs of their class as against the class of capitalists and proprietors, should use that liberty to advance toward a more equitable and more human social organization.

Yet it is undeniable not only that, given individual property and therefore the monopoly of economic power, the liberty left to those who do not hold that monopoly is a powerless and platonic plaything, but also that when the workers show that they mean to use that liberty with a clear consciousness of their class interests, the holders of economic and therefore of political power hasten to disown the great liberal principles, "the principles of '89," and suppress every public liberty, dreaming that they can thus halt the inevitable march of human evolution!

The same may be said of a similar charge against the socialists: that they would disown their country in the name of internationalism.

This too is mistaken.

The national epics by which Italy and Germany won back in our century their unity and their independence were truly a great advance, and we are grateful, we repeat, to those who have given us a free country.

But the Country cannot for that reason become an obstacle to the progress to come, which lies without doubt in the brotherhood of all peoples, without the hatreds of nationality, which are either a survival of barbarism or a varnish concealing the interests of a capitalism that has known, on its own account, how to carry out the closest universal internationalism.

Just as leaving behind the phase of the communal wars of Italy, in order to feel ourselves brothers in one and the same nation, was a real moral and social advance, so will it be to pass beyond the phase of "patriotic" rivalries and feel ourselves all brothers of one and the same humanity.

That it suits the classes in power, bound together as they are in a close international league (the banker of London, with the telegraph,

controls the market of Peking or of New York), to keep the great family of the workers of the whole world, or even of old Europe alone, divided—because the division of the workers makes the power of the capitalists possible—and that this division should be disguised and kept alive by an abuse of the primitive and savage fund of hatred of “the foreigner”: all this is understood and clearly explained by the historical key of class interests.

But that does not alter the fact that internationalist socialism constitutes, on this side too, an undeniable moral advance and an inevitable phase of human evolution.

* * *

In the same way and by the same sociological law it would not be exact to say that socialism will end by suppressing, along with collective property, all individual property, or any individual property at all.

We come back always to this: a succeeding phase of evolution cannot blot out everything achieved in the earlier phases, but suppresses only those manifestations which are not vital because they are in contradiction with the new conditions of existence of the new phase.

Once private property has been replaced by social property in the land and in the means of production, it is plain, for instance, that property in the food necessary to the individual cannot be suppressed, nor property in clothing and articles of personal use, which will be consumed for the exclusive good of the individual or the family.

This form of individual property will therefore always subsist, even under the collectivist regime, because it is inevitable and perfectly compatible with social property in land, in mines, in factories, in houses, in machines, in the tools of labor, in the means of transport.

Just as, for example, the collective property of libraries—which exists and works before our eyes—does not prevent individuals from the personal use of rare or costly books which they could not otherwise possess, but immensely increases their usefulness compared with the same book shut up and buried in the private library of a barren bibliophile, so collective property in the land and in the means of production, by granting to an individual who will have to live by working the use of a machine, of a tool, of a field, will do nothing but multiply its usefulness a hundredfold.

And let it not be said that when men no longer have the exclusive, accumulable and transmissible *ownership* of wealth they will not be inclined to work, for want of the selfish spring of personal or family interest. We see, for instance, even in the individualist world of today, that the surviving remnants of collective property in land—which have been so much studied since Laveleye so brilliantly drew the attention of sociologists to them—are cultivated and yield a return not inferior to that of fields in private ownership, even though the communists of such “shares,” the agrarian collectivists, have no more than the right to use and enjoy them.

And if some of these remnants of collective property—less remote from the whirlpool of commercial individualism—are disappearing and are badly administered, the fact proves nothing against socialism, because it is understandable that in the present economic order, wholly oriented by absolute individualism, those organisms do not find in our environment the conditions of a possible existence.

It would be like expecting a fish to live out of water, or a mammal in an atmosphere without oxygen.

And that, in parenthesis, is why all the famous experiments in socialist, communist or anarchist colonies that some people try to plant here and there as a “preliminary experiment in socialism” are simply fanciful, since they fail to notice that such experiments must inevitably miscarry, because they would have to develop surrounded by an individualist economic and moral environment which cannot allow them the conditions of physiological development they will have when the whole social organization has been collectively oriented, that is, when the whole of society has been *socialized*.

Then individual psychological tendencies and aptitudes too will adapt themselves to the environment and will reflect it; since it is natural that in an individualist environment of free competition, where every man sees in his brother, if not an adversary, at least a competitor, antisocial selfishness must be the tendency that inevitably develops most, by the necessity of the instinct of self-preservation, and most of all in these last phases of a civilization driven at full steam, compared with the peaceful and slow individualism of past centuries.

But in an environment where, on the contrary, in exchange for the manual or intellectual labor given to society, every man has his daily

bread of body and mind assured, and is thus withdrawn from the daily anxiety over his own existence, it is plain that selfishness will have an infinitely smaller number of spurs, of occasions and of manifestations, in the presence of the sense of solidarity, of sympathy, of altruism, and the pitiless maxim *homo homini lupus*, which, confessed or not, so poisons our present life, will no longer hold true.

Unable to dwell any longer on these details, I close the examination of this second alleged opposition between evolution and socialism by recalling that the sociological law—by which the succeeding phase does not blot out the vital and fruitful manifestations of the earlier phases of evolution—gives, as to the social organization already on the way to being formed, an idea more positive than our adversaries suppose, who always think they have before them the romantic and sentimental socialism of the first half of this century.

And that, in short, is why there is no substance whatever in this fundamental objection lately raised against socialism by Tansú, in the name of a sociological eclecticism, erudite but inconclusive, for all the talent and learning of that distinguished philosopher of law:

“Contemporary socialism does not identify itself with individualism, because it lays down as the basis of social organization a principle which is not that of the autonomy of the individual but, on the contrary, its negation. If nevertheless it retains individualist ideas repugnant to that principle, this does not mean that it changes its nature or ceases to be socialism: *it means only that socialism lives on contradictions.*”

Now, it is not that socialism, in admitting and even in enlarging and securing, along with the conditions of daily existence, the strengthening and the development of every human individuality, falls into a contradiction of principle; it is that socialism, on the contrary, as a later phase of human civilization, cannot suppress or blot out what is vital in the earlier forms and compatible with the new social form.

And therefore, just as socialist internationalism is not in contradiction with the existence of one's country, since it admits the idea of it in whatever truth it holds, while removing from it the pathological part of *chauvinism*, so socialism does not live on contradictions but follows the fundamental laws of natural evolution when it preserves and develops the vital part of individualism, while suppressing its pathological manifestations, through which, as Rampolini said, we have in

the modern world a social organism in which ninety per cent of the cells are condemned to anemia only because ten per cent are diseased with hyperemia and consequent hypertrophy.

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CHAPTER XI

EVOLUTION, REVOLUTION, REBELLION, PERSONAL VIOLENCE. SOCIALISM AND ANARCHY

The last and gravest contradiction that many believe they find between socialism and the scientific theory of evolution lies in *how* socialism is to be realized in practice.

On one side some people demand that socialism should present here and now, in every one of its smallest details, the precise and symmetrical picture of its positive social organization. "Give me a practical description of the new society and then I shall decide whether I am to prefer it to the present one."

On the other side—and as a consequence of this first mistaken and artificialist notion—it is believed that socialism means to change the face of the world between one day and the next, so that, for instance, we should all go to bed tonight under the bourgeois regime and wake up tomorrow in the middle of a socialist world.

And then—so the argument runs—how can we fail to see that all this comes hopelessly into conflict with the law of evolution, whose two fundamental ideas—which are precisely what marks off the new development of modern positive thought from the old metaphysics—are the *naturalness* and the *gradualness* of all phenomena in every order of universal life, from astronomy to sociology?

It is undeniable that these two objections had much reason on their side against what Engels called "utopian socialism," as opposed to "scientific socialism."

When socialism, before Karl Marx, was nothing but the sentimental expression of a humanitarianism as generous as it was destitute of the most elementary principles of scientific positivism, it is perfectly

understandable that its followers or defenders should have yielded easily to the impulses of the heart, whether in noisy protests against evident social iniquities or in the sleepwalking contemplation of a better world to which fancy tried to give definite outlines, from Plato's *Republic* to Bellamy's *Looking Backward (In the Year 2000)*.

And it is still easier to understand that these constructions *a priori* were bound to give a handle to criticism, partly mistaken, since such criticism always depends on the mental habits proper to the modern environment and forgets that they will be different in a different environment, but also in great part well founded, because the enormous complexity of social phenomena makes it impossible to prophesy the insignificant details of a social life that will be more radically unlike our own than present life is unlike that of the Middle Ages and of antiquity, for the reason that the bourgeois world which succeeded those before it left society upon the same cardinal points of individualism, whereas the socialist world will have a fundamentally different polarity.

These anticipatory and prophetic constructions of a new social order are, besides, the genuine mark of that political and social artificialism in which even the most orthodox and Jacobin individualists are steeped, believing as they always do, as Spencer himself observes, that human society is a dough to which article *such-and-such* of any statute can give one shape rather than another, quite apart from the organic and mental, ethnic and historical qualities, tendencies and aptitudes of different peoples . . .

Continental socialism has furnished many attempts at utopian construction; but the political world of today has furnished and furnishes more, with the absurd and chaotic jumble of its laws and its codes, which (so much for liberty! . . .) wrap every man from his birth to his death, and even before he is born and after he is dead, in an inextricable net of codes, laws, decrees, regulations and the rest, smothering him like a silkworm in its cocoon . . .

And every day experience shows that our legislators, steeped in this political and social artificialism, do nothing but copy from one another the laws of the most diverse peoples, according as the fashion runs to Paris or to Berlin, and amuse their countries with them, instead of drawing from those same countries the positive criteria by which

laws should be fitted to them; so that the laws, for that very reason and as happens every day, remain a dead letter, since the reality of things does not allow them to drive their roots deep, or to regulate and fertilize its vital points.

As for artificial social constructions, socialists may say to the individualists:

“Let him who is without sin cast the first stone!”

But the true and irrefutable answer is that scientific socialism represents a far more advanced phase of socialist ideas, in agreement precisely with modern positive science, and has completely abandoned the fanciful idea of prophesying today what human society will be under the new collectivist organization.

What scientific socialism can affirm, and does affirm with mathematical certainty, is that the direction, the trajectory of human evolution moves in the general sense indicated and foreseen by socialism, that is, in the sense of a continual and progressive preponderance of the interests and advantages of the species over the interests and advantages of the individual, and consequently in the sense of the continual *socialization* of economic life and through it of the juridical, moral and political life that depends on it.

As for the smallest details of the new social edifice, we cannot foresee them, precisely because that new social edifice will be, and is, a *natural* and *spontaneous* product of human evolution, already on the way to being formed and with its general lines already sketched in embryo, and not the immediate and artificial construction imagined in the study of some utopian or metaphysician.

It is the same in the social sciences as in the natural sciences.

If you give a biologist a human embryo only a few days or a few weeks old to examine, he will not be able to tell you—by the well-known Haeckelian law that the development of every *individual* embryo reproduces as a whole the various forms of development of the *species* that have preceded it in the zoological series—he will not be able to tell you, I repeat, whether it will be male or female, and still less will he be able to foresee whether it will be a robust or a weak individual, sanguine or nervous, intelligent or not.

He will be able to tell you only the general lines of the future evolution of that individual, leaving to time the task of defining naturally

and spontaneously—according to hereditary organic conditions and the conditions of the environment in which it will live—the endlessly varied details of its personality.

So the socialist can and must answer, exactly as Bebel did in the German Reichstag, replying in an eloquent speech to those who wanted to know from the socialists, here and now, what the future State will be in its details, and who, skillfully taking advantage of the naïveté of the socialist romancers, criticize their anticipatory artificial fancies, true in their general lines but far too arbitrary in their details.

The same thing would have happened if before the French Revolution—which brought to flower the bourgeois world, prepared and ripened in the evolution that went before—the aristocratic and clerical classes, then in power, had said to the representatives of the third estate—bourgeois by birth, or aristocrats and priests who embraced the cause of the bourgeoisie against the privileges of their own caste, like the Marquis de Mirabeau and the Abbé Sieyès—had said to them, I repeat: “But what will your new world be like? Give us its exact plan first and then we shall decide.”

The third estate, the bourgeoisie, would not have known how to answer then, nor could it have foreseen the aspect of human society in the nineteenth century; and yet that did not prevent the bourgeois revolution from taking place, because it represented the later, natural and inevitable phase of an eternal evolution, just as socialism now stands face to face with the bourgeois world. And if that bourgeois world, born little more than a century ago, has a far shorter historical cycle than the feudal world (aristocratic and clerical), it will only be because the marvelous scientific advances of the nineteenth century, having multiplied a hundredfold the speed of life in time and in space, now make civilized humanity travel in ten years the same road it used to travel in a century or two of the Middle Ages.

The continually accelerating speed of human evolution is precisely another of the laws established and confirmed by positive social science.

And it is from these artificial constructions of sentimental socialism that the impression—a just one so far as they are concerned—has arisen and taken root that *socialism* is a synonym for *tyranny*.

It is natural enough: if you understand the new social order not as the spontaneous form of an immanent human evolution but as an arti-

ficial construction springing from the brain of a social architect, that architect cannot escape the necessity of disciplining the new machinery with an endless number of regulations and with the supreme power of a directing mind, individual or collective. And then one understands how such a socialist organization leaves upon our adversaries—who see only the advantages of liberty in the individualist world and forget the plague spots that are freely gangrening it—the impression of a convent, of a regimentation or something of the kind.

And another contemporary artificial product has come to confirm this impression—*State socialism*—which is fundamentally the same thing as sentimental or utopian socialism, and which, as Liebknecht said at the Berlin Congress of 1892, would only be “a State capitalism that would add political slavery to economic exploitation.” So-called State socialism can give proof of the irresistible power of suggestion possessed by scientific and democratic socialism—as the famous *rescripts* of the Emperor William show, summoning an international conference—to solve (even with the childish notion of the Decree) the problems of labor; or else there is the famous encyclical *De conditione opificum* of that most skillful pope Leo XIII, which hits the nail once and the horseshoe the next time. But imperial Rescripts and papal Encyclicals—since the phases of evolution can neither be suppressed nor skipped—could only miscarry in the midst of a bourgeois, individualist and *liberista* world which would not be sorry to crush the all too vigorous socialism of our day in the loving embrace of official artificialism and State socialism, now that it has been proved in Germany and elsewhere that neither exceptional laws nor exceptional repression avail against it.

All this arsenal of regulations and superintendences has nothing to do with scientific socialism, which foresees with the utmost clearness that the direction of the new social order, necessary for the administration of collective property, will be in no way more complicated than what is now needed for the administration of the State, the Provinces and the Communes, and that on the contrary it will answer far better to social and individual advantage, as a natural—and not a parasitic—product of the new social organism; just as the nervous system of a mammal, the regulating apparatus of its organism, is more complicated than the organism of a fish or a mollusk, but without any tyrannical

nical smothering of the autonomy of the other organs and systems, down to the cells, in their living confederation.

It is understood, then, that anyone who wishes to refute socialism seriously must not repeat the customary objections which apply to artificialist and sentimental socialism, which I do not deny may still survive in the nebulous mass of popular ideas, but which is losing ground every day among the conscious adherents—of popular, bourgeois or aristocratic origin—of that scientific socialism which, armed by the brilliant impulse of Karl Marx with all the most positive inferences of modern science, rises triumphant over the stale objections still repeated by our adversaries out of mere mental habit, but which have already vanished from the contemporary conscience together with the utopian socialism that gave rise to them.

* * *

The same answer serves for the second part of the objection, which concerns the manner in which the coming of socialism will be brought about.

It is an inevitable and logical consequence of utopian and artificialist socialism to think that the architectural construction proposed by this or that reformer must or can be applied between one day and the next by decree of a king or of a people.

And in this sense the utopian illusion of empirical socialism stands in opposition to the positive law of evolution, and is therefore mistaken. And precisely *as such* I attacked it in my *Socialism and Crime*, because at that time (1883) the ideas of scientific or Marxist socialism had not yet spread in Italy.

A political party or a scientific theory is also a natural product which must pass through the vital phases of infancy and youth before reaching its full development. It was inevitable, therefore, that before becoming scientific and positive, socialism in Italy and in other countries should pass through the infantile phases both of corporative exclusivism (of *manual* workers only) and of the nebulous romanticism which, giving the word *revolution* a narrow and incomplete meaning, has always clung to the illusion that a social organism can be radically changed between one day and the next with four volleys of musketry, in the way a monarchical regime can be changed into a republican one.

But to change the political shell of a social order is immensely easier—because it is less conclusive and has less influence upon the economic ground of social life—than to give that social life a different orientation in its economic constitution.

The processes of social transformation are, as under other names they are for every transformation of living beings: evolution, revolution, rebellion, personal violence.

A mineral, vegetable or animal species may pass in the cycle of its existence through these same processes of transformation.

From the moment when the first nucleus of crystallization, or the germ, or the embryo increases gradually in structure and in volume, we have a gradual and continuous process of *evolution*, which in one way or another must be followed by a more or less prolonged process of *revolution*, represented for instance by the complete detachment of the crystal from the surrounding mineral mass, or by certain revolutionary phases of vegetable or animal life, such as the moment of sexual reproduction; and so too there may occur some moment of *rebellion*, that is, of associated individual violence, as happens so often among the animal species that live in society; and there may also occur isolated *personal violence*, as in the struggles for the winning of food or of the female among animals of the same species.

In the human world the same processes are repeated, *evolution* being understood as the daily transformation, almost unnoticed but continuous and inevitable; *revolution* as the critical and decisive period, more or less prolonged, of an evolution that has reached its term; *rebellion* as the partially collective violence that breaks out through the provocation of this or that particular circumstance at a given point and a given moment; and *personal violence* as the attempt of one individual against one or several individuals, which may be either the effect of an outburst of fanatical passion, or the explosion of criminal instincts, or the manifestation of mental unbalance—with links to whatever ideas, political or religious, are most in vogue at a given moment.

Now, the first observation to be made is this: that while evolution and revolution belong to social physiology, rebellion and personal violence are on the contrary symptoms of social pathology.

It is true that all of them are natural and spontaneous processes, since, according to the conception of Virchow, who in great part renewed modern biology, pathology is nothing but the continuation of

physiology, and even the pathological symptoms have, or ought to have, great diagnostic value for the classes in power, which in every historical epoch, in moments of political crisis as in moments of social crisis, can think of no other remedy than personal repression, guillotining or imprisoning, and imagining that they have thereby cured the constitutional and organic disease that is working in the social body.

But it is in any case irrefutable that the normal processes of social transformation—and therefore the most fruitful and surest, even when they appear slower and less effective—are evolution and revolution, the latter understood in the exact and positive sense of the last phase of a preceding evolution, and not turned into a synonym for tumultuous and violent rebellion, as people commonly and mistakenly suppose.

Indeed, it is plain that at the close of the nineteenth century Europe and America are already in a period of revolution, prepared by the earlier evolution which the bourgeois organization itself fertilized and which socialism, first utopian and then scientific, carried on; so that we are now not only in that critical period of social life which Bagehot called “the age of discussion,” but there can already be seen what Zola in his marvelous *Germinal* called the cracking of the political and social framework, by all the symptoms that Taine describes in almost the same words in his *Ancien Régime*, in narrating the twenty years before 1789. Symptoms by which—as partial escapes of volcanic vapors and gases issue here and there through the fissures of the social ground—we have an indication that the whole earth’s crust is yielding to the pressure of an internal revolution, against which repressive measures upon this or that fissure will be of no use whatever, while all those wise laws of reform and foresight which, even while serving the present, would make “the birth pangs of the new society” less painful, as Marx said, might be most effective and most fruitful in benefits.

And this is why, understood in this positive sense, evolution and revolution present themselves as the most fruitful and surest processes of social metamorphosis.

Precisely because human society is a natural and living organism, it cannot, any more than any other, undergo immediate and sudden transformations, as those imagine who maintain that we must have recourse solely, or first of all, to rebellion or to personal violence for

the realization of a new social order. It would be like expecting a child or a youth to complete a given biological evolution in a single day—even in the revolutionary period of puberty—and turn at once into an adult.

It is understandable, however, that the unemployed man, under the convulsions of hunger, or in the mental exhaustion caused by want of food, or in the daydreams of ignorance, should imagine that by dealing a blow to a policeman, or throwing a bomb, or making a barricade or a riot, he will come nearer to the realization of an ideal of less social iniquity.

And even apart from this case, it is understandable that the impelling force of sentiment, prevailing in certain men, may drive them by generous impatience to some attempt—even a real one, and not imaginary like those which the police of every time and place have always produced—and so to the repression of the courts, to humor the mania or the panic terror of those who feel political or economic power slipping out of their hands.

But the tactics of scientific socialism, especially in Germany through the more direct influence of Marxism, have completely abandoned these old methods of revolutionary romanticism, which, repeated so many times, have always miscarried, and are therefore in substance less feared by the ruling classes, because they are slight localized shocks against a fortress still solid enough and more to come off victorious over them, and to secure by the victory of the moment a delay in evolution, through the eliminating selection of the boldest and strongest adversaries.

Marxist socialism is revolutionary in the scientific sense of the word, and is unfolding now in the midst of a social revolution, for no one will deny that the close of the nineteenth century marks the critical phase of a bourgeois evolution driven at full steam, elsewhere more than in Italy, along the road of individualist capitalism.

And Marxist socialism has the frankness to say, through the mouths of its most cultivated representatives, to the great sorrowing phalanx of the modern proletariat, that it has no magic wand for changing the world overnight as the scenery of a theater is changed when the curtain rises; but it says also, with the fateful rallying cry that Marx flung out to the world of the workers: *Workers of the whole*

world, unite!, that the social revolution cannot reach its term unless it has first ripened in the consciousness of the workers themselves, with a clear vision of their class interests and of the force immanent in them when they are united, and not with the belief that they can wake up one day in the middle of a socialist regime merely because, after lying inert and divided for 364 days of the year, it should come into their heads on the 365th to give themselves up to some rebellion or some personal violence.

This is the psychology I call the “lucky number in the lottery,” by which the workers, and all those wounded by poverty, dream—without doing anything to form themselves into a conscious class party—of one fine day drawing the lucky number in the lottery of the social revolution, as manna is said to have fallen from heaven upon the Jews.

Scientific socialism shows, then, how the transforming power grows less from one process to the next: as we pass from evolution to revolution, from revolution to rebellion, and from rebellion to personal violence. Precisely because what is at stake is a transformation of the whole of society in its economic basis and therefore in its juridical, political and moral organizations, for that very reason the process of transformation is the more effective and the better suited the more *social* and the less *individual* it is.

The individualist parties are personalist in their daily struggle too; socialism, on the contrary, is collectivist in that same struggle, because it knows that the present order does not depend on this or that individual but on society as a whole. And that, by the opposite token, is why *charity*, being necessarily personal or partial for all its generosity, cannot be a remedy for the social and therefore collective question of the distribution of wealth.

In a political question, which leaves the economic and social basis untouched, it is easy to see how the exile of Napoleon III or of Dom Pedro II can set up a republic. But that superficial transformation will not touch the ground of social life, and the German Empire or the Italian monarchy are socially bourgeois just as the French Republic or the United States are; because in spite of differences in their *political* varnish they belong to the same *economic and social* phase.

That is why the processes of evolution and revolution, the only completely social or collective ones, are the most effective, while par-

tial rebellion, and much more personal violence, hold in themselves only the remotest energy of social transformation, and on the contrary contain so much that is antisocial and antihuman, since they awaken the primitive instincts of blood and fratricide, and along with the *person* of the man struck down they offend the very principle by which they believe themselves inspired: the principle of respect for human life and of solidarity.

It matters little to hypnotize oneself with the phrases "propaganda of the deed" or "immediate action."

As is well known, the anarchists who are individualists or "amorphists" admit as a means of social transformation *personal violence*, which runs from homicide to theft even among comrades, and which is then plainly nothing but a political varnish laid over criminal instincts, not to be confounded with political fanaticism, which is a very different phenomenon and common to the extreme and romantic parties of every epoch. And only the positive examination of each particular case can decide, with the help of anthropology and psychology, whether the author of this or that personal violence is a born criminal, an insane criminal, or a criminal by passion and political fanaticism.

Indeed, I have always held and hold today that the "political criminal," of whom some would make a special category, does not constitute an anthropological variety, but may belong to any of the anthropological categories of ordinary criminals, and especially to one of these three: either the *born* criminal by congenital tendency, or the *insane* criminal, or the criminal by the impulse of fanatical *passion*.

The history of the past and that of our own day offer plain examples.

Just as in the Middle Ages religious beliefs occupied the universal conscience and gave their color to the criminal or demented excesses of many unbalanced persons, or even really produced cases of a "sanctity" more or less hysterical, so at the close of our century the political and social questions which occupy the universal conscience more violently—a conscience which is also more universally inflamed by the contagion produced by journalism with its great *réclame*—are the ones that give their color to the criminal or demented excesses of many unbalanced persons, or produce cases of fanaticism in men who are truly honest but hyperesthetic.

And political and social questions, in the extreme form they take at each historical moment, are naturally those that possess this suggestive power most intensely. Sixty years ago in Italy it was *Mazzinianism* or *Carbonarism*; twenty years ago *socialism*; now *anarchism* . . .

And so one understands how personal violence has been committed in every age and according to the color of the age . . . Orsini, for instance, figures among the martyrs of the Italian revolution.

Now, apart from the inevitably mistaken judgments dictated by the emotion of the moment, the decision on each case of *personal violence* ought to be nothing but the fruit of a physio-psychical examination of its author, as with any other crime.

Orsini was a political criminal by the impulse of passion. Among the bomb-throwing or dagger-wielding anarchists of our own day one may find the born criminal—who nevertheless disguises his congenital want of moral or social sense with a political varnish—as well as the insane criminal or the mattoid, who refers his mental unbalance to the political ideas of the moment; just as one may also find the criminal by political *passion*, truly convinced and reasonably normal, in whom the violent act is brought about only by the false notion (which socialism combats) of a possible *social* transformation by means of *personal* violence.

Be that as it may, whether we have to do with a born or an insane criminal, or with a political criminal by the impulse of passion, it remains true that *personal violence*, adopted by the individualist anarchists, while it is the logical product of individualism carried to extremes, and therefore of the present economic organization carried to its extremes—with its accompanying “delirium of hunger,” acute or chronic—is the least effective and the most inhuman means of social transformation.

But besides the individualist, amorphist or autonomist anarchists there are also the communist anarchists.

These repudiate *personal violence* as an ordinary means of social transformation (and among others Merlino lately declared as much in his pamphlet *The Necessity and Basis of an Agreement*); nevertheless these communist anarchists differ from Marxist socialism not only in the ultimate *ideal* but also and above all in the *method* of social transformation, for while attacking the Marxist socialists as “legalitarians”

and “parliamentarians,” they maintain that the most effective and surest means of social transformation is *rebellion*.

With such assertions, which answer only too well to the nebulousness of the feelings and ideas of a very large part of the workers and to their impatience with their wretched situation, they may have an unconscious momentary influence; but their action is bound to be as transitory as foam on water, just as the explosion of a bomb may produce a certain momentary excitement but does not advance by a single step the evolution of men’s minds toward socialism, while on the contrary it brings about a reaction of feeling, in great part sincere but also skillfully fostered and used as a pretext for repression.

To tell the workers that they must rebel against the classes that hold power, without preparation not only in material means but also in solidarity and in moral consciousness, is rather to serve the interests of those ruling classes, since they are certain of material victory, the evolution not being ripe and the revolution not being ready.

That is why, in spite of all the interested falsehoods, it was seen in the recent movements in Sicily that where socialism was most advanced there occurred neither personal violence nor rebellion, as among the peasants of Piana dei Greci, trained in conscious socialism by Nicola Barbato; whereas those convulsive movements appeared either outside socialist propaganda, as a rebellion against the exactions and the municipal *communes*, or else where a less conscious socialist propaganda was overtaken by the impulses of hunger and want.

History teaches that the countries where rebellions have been most frequent are those whose social progress is least advanced, precisely because the energies of the people are stirred up and torn to pieces in these feverish and convulsive excesses, and, alternating with periods of exhaustion and mistrust—to which the Buddhist theory of *abstention from voting* corresponds, so convenient for the conservative parties—they represent no continuity of that conscious action which is apparently slower and less effective but is in reality the only action able to achieve what seem to be the miracles of history.

That is why Marxist socialism in every country has proclaimed that the chief means of social transformation must be *the conquest of the public powers* (in local administrations and in parliaments), as one of the effects of the conscious organization of the workers in a single class

party; while as that organization grows more intense and more extended, other effects will follow, truly revolutionary in the positive sense already explained. The further the political organization of the workers advances in civilized countries, the more they will see realized, by inevitable evolution, the socialist organization of society: first with the partial but ever wider concessions of the capitalist class to the working class (an eloquent example: the law of the *eight hours*) and afterward with the complete transformation of individual property into social property.

Whether this integral transformation, which, preparing itself by gradual evolution, is nearing the critical and decisive moment of the social revolution, may afterward be carried out with or without the help of the other means of transformation—rebellion and personal violence—is what no one can prophesy.

Our sincere hope is that the social revolution may be accomplished peacefully, when the evolution is ripe, like so many other revolutions that have been made in peace, without the shedding of a drop of blood: for example the English Revolution which preceded the French by a century with the *Bill of Rights*; like the Italian Revolution made in Tuscany in 1859; like the Brazilian Revolution, made with the exile of the Emperor Dom Pedro in 1892.

And it is plain that the wider culture of the people and their conscious organization as a class party under the banner of socialism can only increase the chances of that hope of ours, and dispel as well the stale predictions of a period of *reaction* after the coming of socialism, predictions that would have some reason for existing only if socialism were still utopian in its means of action, instead of being, as it is, the natural and spontaneous and therefore inevitable and irrevocable phase of human evolution.

And where will this social revolution begin?

I am firmly convinced that while the Latin peoples, as southerners, are more apt at sudden rebellions and may achieve purely *political* transformations, the northern peoples, German or Anglo-Saxon, are better disposed to the calm but inexorable discipline of the true revolution, as the critical phase of a preceding organic and gradual evolution, the only effective process of a truly *social* transformation.

And it is in Germany or in England, where the greater development of bourgeois individualism inevitably hastens its drawbacks and

therefore the need of socialism, that the great social metamorphosis, already begun everywhere as well, will probably be accomplished, and from there it will spread through old Europe, as at the close of the last century the signal of the political and bourgeois revolution went out from France.

* * *

Once more, then, the profound difference between socialism and anarchism is demonstrated—a difference which our adversaries and the servile press are pleased to blur before eyes veiled by emotion or by ignorance—and it is in any case demonstrated that Marxist socialism represents a vital harmony with, and a fruitful continuation of, positive science, precisely because it has made the theory of evolution the sap and the blood of its own inferences, and therefore marks the truly living and definitive phase—and consequently the only one that will henceforth survive in the conscience of collectivist democracy—of that socialism which until lately had remained floating in the mists of sentimentalism, without the infallible compass of a scientific thought renewed by the works of Darwin and of Spencer.

PART THREE



SOCIOLOGY AND SOCIALISM

CHAPTER XII

THE BARREN LIMBO OF SOCIOLOGY

A truly strange phenomenon in the history of thought after the first half of the nineteenth century was this:

The profound scientific revolution brought about by Darwinism and Spencerism had invaded, and renewed with fresh youth, every branch of the physical, biological and psychological sciences; but on reaching the ground of the social sciences it had done no more than ruffle the surface of the calm orthodox lake of the social science par excellence: political economy.

It is true that on the initiative of Auguste Comte—overshadowed in part by the names of Darwin and Spencer, but beyond doubt one of the grandest and most fruitful intellects of our age—on his initiative, it is true, a new science was created: sociology, which as the natural history of human societies ought to have been the glorious crowning of the new scientific edifice raised by the experimental method. Nor do I deny that sociology, in the part that is pure descriptive anatomy of the social organism, has brought great and fruitful novelties to contemporary science, branching out too into various special sociologies, one of whose most useful and most living results is criminal sociology, created by the Italian positive school.

But whenever the political and social question was approached, the new science of sociology was seized by a kind of hypnotic sleep, and, hanging suspended in a colorless and odorless limbo, allowed the sociologists to be, in public economy as in politics, now conservatives, now radicals, according to their whim and their personal leanings.

And while Darwinian biology, with its study of the relations between the individual and the species, and evolutionist sociology itself, by determining in human society the organs and functions of a true

living organism, reduced the individual in the social organism to the relative proportion of a cell in the animal organism, Herbert Spencer declared himself an Anglican individualist, to the point of the most absolute theoretical anarchism.

A stagnation in the scientific output of sociology was therefore inevitable after its first original observations in descriptive social anatomy and in the natural history of human societies. Sociology thus represented an arrest of development in experimental scientific thought, because its cultivators, consciously and unconsciously, drew back from the logical and radical conclusions which the modern scientific revolution was bound to carry into the social field—the field that matters most, if positivism means to make science for the sake of life, rather than to stop at the onanistic formula of science for the sake of science.

The easy secret of this strange phenomenon lies not only, as Malagodi noted, in sociology's being in the period of scientific *analysis* before reaching *synthesis*, but above all in the fact that the logical consequences of Darwinism and of scientific evolutionism, applied to the study of human society, lead inevitably to socialism, as I have shown in these pages.

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CHAPTER XIII

MARX COMPLETES DARWIN AND SPENCER. CONSERVATIVES AND SOCIALISTS

The credit of having given scientific expression to these logical applications of scientific experimentalism in the field of social economy—though wrapped in a jumble of technical details and seemingly dogmatic formulas, as happens for that matter in Spencer's *First Principles*, where the luminous paragraphs on *evolution* are wrapped in the fog of abstractions about time, space, the unknowable and the rest—belongs to Karl Marx. And his scientific work, smothered until a few years ago by a kind of conspiracy of silence on the part of orthodox science, now shines with inextinguishable light and places him beyond dispute beside Charles Darwin and Herbert Spencer, completing the trinity of the scientific revolution that is stirring the thought of the civilized world in the second half of the nineteenth century with the thrill of a new intellectual spring.

There are three brilliant ideas in particular by which Karl Marx completed the revolution brought about by positive science in the field of political economy.

The discovery of the law of *surplus value*, in which, however, a technical character predominates—as the positive explanation of the accumulation of private property divorced from labor—a matter on which we need not dwell, since an elementary idea of it has been given in the preceding pages.

The other two Marxist theories are of far greater interest for our general observations on scientific socialism, because they truly give the sure and infallible key to all the secrets of social life.

I refer to the idea expressed as early as 1859 in the *Critique of Po-*

litical Economy, that the economic phenomenon is the basis and the condition of every human and social manifestation; and that therefore morals, law and politics are nothing but phenomena derived from the economic factor, according to the conditions of each people in each phase of history and in each zone of the earth.

And this idea, which answers to the great biological law by which function is determined by organ, and by which every man is such as he turns out to be from the innate and acquired conditions of his physiological organism living in a given environment—so that a truly biological extension may be given to the famous saying “tell me how you eat and I will tell you who you are”—this brilliant idea, which really unrolls before our eyes the grand drama of human life, no longer as the capricious succession of great men on the stage of the social theater but as the resultant of the economic conditions of each people, has been explained, after some partial applications by Thorold Rogers, so powerfully by Achille Loria that I think it useless to add anything of my own.

One idea alone I think necessary to complete this Marxist theory, as I already maintained in the first edition of *Socialism and Crime*.

That irrefutable theory has to be stripped of the kind of one-sided dogmatism it has been taking on in Marx and still more in Loria.

It is true that every social, moral, juridical or political phenomenon and institution is nothing but the repercussion of the economic phenomenon and of economic conditions at each moment of the physical and historical environment.

But by the law of natural causation, by which every effect is always the resultant of many linked causes and not of one alone, and every effect becomes in its turn the cause of other phenomena, this too schematic form of a true idea needs to be completed.

As all the mental manifestations of the individual are the resultant of his organic conditions (temperament) and of the environment in which he lives, so all the social manifestations of a people—moral, juridical, political—are the resultant of its organic conditions (race) and of the environment, in so far as these determine a given economic organization, which is the physical basis of life.

But just as afterward and in their turn the resulting mental conditions of the individual influence, though with less efficacy—the effect turned into cause—his organic conditions and the outcome of

his struggle for life, so too moral, juridical and political institutions in their turn become from effects causes (there being for positive science no *substantial* difference between cause and effect, except that the effect is the constant sequel of a given phenomenon and the cause its constant antecedent), and therefore react, with much less efficacy, upon economic conditions.

For example, an individual who knows something of hygiene may influence the imperfections of his digestive apparatus, but always within the very narrow limits of his organic potentiality—as a scientific discovery or an electoral law may influence industry or the conditions of labor, but within the lines of the fundamental economic organization. Thus moral, juridical and political institutions produce far greater effects upon the relations among the various categories of the class that holds economic power (capitalists, manufacturers and landed proprietors) than upon the relations between the capitalist proprietors on one side and the workers on the other.

In any case—and referring the reader who wishes to see how, by this Marxist law, all the phenomena of social life, from the smallest to the grandest, are positively explained, to Loria's suggestive book—it is enough for me to have recalled it here, because it is truly the most positive, the most fruitful, the most brilliant sociological theory ever put forward, and by it, I repeat, social history in its grandest dramas and individual history in its smallest episodes alike obtain a positive, physiological, experimental explanation—in full agreement with that direction of modern scientific thought which has been called materialist.

Human history has had two one-sided and therefore incomplete explanations, though positive and scientific—setting aside the unscientific explanations of free will or of divine providence—and these are the *telluric determinism* maintained from Montesquieu to Buckle and Metschnikoff, and the *anthropological determinism* maintained by all the ethnologists who limited the historical reason of events to the organic and mental characters of race.

Karl Marx with his *economic determinism* sums up and completes the two theories, making them truly psychological.

Economic conditions—which are the resultant of *ethnic* energies and aptitudes at work in a given *telluric* environment—are the de-

termining basis of all the other manifestations—moral, juridical, political—of human existence, individual and social.

Such is the brilliant Marxist theory, positive and scientific if ever a theory was, supported as it is by the surest inquiries of geology and biology, of psychology and sociology.

Only by means of it can the philosophers of law and the sociologists determine the true nature and the functions of the *State*, which, being nothing else than "*Society* juridically and politically organized," is plainly nothing but the secular arm at the disposal of the class that holds economic power—and therefore political, juridical and administrative power—for keeping its own privileges and giving up as little of them, and as late, as possible.

* * *

The other sociological theory by which Karl Marx has really thinned the darkness that until now overshadowed the sky of socialist aspirations—aspirations which nevertheless, by the mere fact of their existence through the centuries, have the confirmation of answering instinctively to the truth of things—and has given scientific socialism the political compass by which to steer with complete confidence in the debate of daily life, is the historical law of the *class struggle*.

Once it is established that the economic conditions of social groups, like those of individuals, are the determining foundation of every other moral, juridical and political manifestation of theirs, it is plain that any social group, like any individual, will be driven to act according to its economic advantage, since that is the physical basis of life and the condition of every other kind of existence; and therefore it is plain that in the political order every social class will be driven to make laws, to set up institutions, to consecrate customs and beliefs that answer to its direct or indirect advantage.

Laws, institutions and beliefs which afterward, by hereditary transmission and by tradition, veil and conceal their economic origin, and are therefore very often upheld and defended by jurists and philosophers, or by laymen as well, as truths existing in their own right, without their perceiving their real source; but that remains the only positive explanation of those laws, institutions and beliefs. And it is precisely there that the brilliant power of Karl Marx's insight lies.

And since in the modern world the classes are clearly and substantially two, in spite of their accessory varieties—on one side the *workers*, of whatever category they may belong to, and on the other the *non-working* proprietors—in its practical conclusions and in political discipline the socialist theory of Karl Marx leads to this evident result: that as political parties are nothing but the echo and the mouthpiece of class interests, so too, whatever superficial or methodical varieties there may be, political parties can be substantially only two: the socialist party of the workers and the individualist party of the class that holds the land and the other means of production.

Differences in the kind of economic monopoly may determine a certain diversity of political *color*: and I have always said that the great landed proprietors, for instance, represent the conservative tendencies of political *immobilism*, while the holders of movable or industrial capital often represent the progressive party, naturally inclined to small innovations of form and surface, while those who hold only intellectual capital, the liberal professions and the like, may even go as far as political radicalism.

But in the vital substance of things, that is, in the economic question of property, conservatives, progressives and radicals are all individualists, flesh and marrow of the same social class, and are therefore substantially divided—in spite of sentimental but inconclusive sympathies—from the class of the workers and from those who, though belonging by birth to *the other bank*, explicitly embrace and defend the political program that answers necessarily to the primary and indispensable economic need, namely the socialization of the land and of the means of production, with all the countless and radical moral, juridical and political transformations it will naturally bring about in the social world.

And that, consequently, is why contemporary political life cannot but degenerate into the most barren Byzantinism or the most corrupt commercialism, so long as it confines itself to the surface battles of the individualist parties, divided today only by their heat and their formulistic labels, but so confused in their ideas that one often sees radicals and progressives less modern in social ideas than many conservatives.

Only with the appearance and the strengthening of the socialist party will political life revive and grow healthy, because—once the

historical figures of the patriots and the personal grounds of dispute between the representatives of the various political shades have vanished from the political scene—the forming of that conglomerate of the individualist parties which I announced in the Italian parliament in the sitting of the 20th of December, 1893, will be inevitable, and the symptoms of its formation increase every day.

And then the historical duel will be joined, and the class struggle will then unfold its beneficial influence in the political field as well, not in the mean sense of fisticuffs or insults, of rancors or personal violence, but in the grand sense of a social drama which with all our soul we hope may have, thanks to advanced civilization and culture, an outcome free of bloody convulsions, but which in any case is already fixed by historical necessity, and which neither we nor anyone else can prevent or delay.

As may be seen, these ideas of political socialism lead to that same *personal tolerance* joined to *intransigence in ideas* which is also an effect of positive psychology in the philosophical field, and by which, while we may feel the greatest personal sympathy for this or that representative of the radical section of the individualist party (as, for that matter, for any honest and sincere representative of any scientific, religious or political opinion whatever), we must nevertheless recognize absolutely that for socialism there are no such things as “kindred parties.” Either on this side or on the other—either individualists or socialists—there is no middle road; and I have had to convince myself more and more that the only useful tactic for the formation of a living socialist party is precisely that intransigence of ideas and that refusal of any of the so-called “alliances” with kindred parties, which for socialism can be nothing but a “false placenta” for a fetus that cannot live.

Conservatives and socialists are natural products of individual character and of social environment, for a man is born conservative or innovator as he is born painter or surgeon. Consequently socialists feel neither contempt nor rancor toward the sincere representatives of any section of the conservative party, though they fight their ideas at all costs. If some socialist falls into intolerance or personal *insult*, he is the victim of momentary emotion or of a temperament little balanced and little serene; and he is therefore very excusable.

What does provoke a smile of compassion is to see certain conservatives “young in years but old in thought”—for conservatism in the

young, if it is not a calculation of gain, is a sign of mental anemia—assuming a certain air of self-sufficiency and almost of pity toward the socialists, whom at best they regard as “misguided,” without noticing that while it is normal for the old to be conservative, young conservatives, with few exceptions, are nothing but *egoists* afraid of losing the idle comforts of the life into which they were born, or the conveniences of the orthodox flock. That is to say that they are, if not microcephalic, certainly *microcardiac*. The socialist, meanwhile, who has everything to lose and nothing to gain by upholding his ideas openly, can set against them the whole superiority of his disinterested altruism, and most of all when, born of the aristocratic or the bourgeois class, he turns aside from the flatteries of a brilliant and idle life to defend the cause of the wretched and the oppressed.

“But,” it is said, “these ‘bourgeois socialists’ do it out of love of popularity!” A strange egoism, in any case, in the man who prefers to the “bourgeois individualism” of salaries and sudden gains the “socialist idealism” of popular sympathy, even supposing that such sympathy would not have come to him afterward by other roads and other means that would have compromised him less in the eyes of the class in power.

In any case we hope that when the bourgeoisie has to give up economic and therefore political power, so that it may go to the benefit of all in the new social organization—and victors and vanquished alike, as Berenini put it so well, may become truly human, without distinctions of class, in the common security of a life worthy of human creatures—we hope, I say, that in giving up power the bourgeoisie will give proof of that dignity and respectability which the aristocracy has shown and shows in its sudden stripping as a class, the work of that same bourgeoisie triumphant in the French Revolution.

In any case, this substantial truth of Marxist socialism and its perfect and intimate correspondence with the surest inferences of positive science explain more than sufficiently its immense advances, not only in proselytism—which might also be the purely negative effect of a material and moral distress grown acute in a period of social crisis—but above all in the harmonious unity of discipline and in the conscious solidarity which, in its universal and periodical manifestation of the First of May, presents a moral phenomenon of a grandeur for

which human history offers us no parallel, unless we except the movement of primitive Christianity, which nevertheless had a far narrower field of action than contemporary socialism.

And from today onward—apart from the hysterical or unconscious efforts of a skeptical bourgeoisie to return to mysticism as a way out of the material and moral crisis of the moment, exactly as the licentious woman turns devout in her old age—from today onward adversaries and partisans alike are obliged to recognize that socialism today represents, as Christianity did when the Roman world was falling in ruins, the one force that gives back to the old human civilization the hope of a better future, in the name of a faith born no longer of the unconscious impulses of sentiment but of the conscious certainty of positive science.

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